BILLABLE PERPETUITY

A Novel

Prologue & Part One · First Draft · 2025

PROLOGUE

In Perpetuity

Olena — 2031

The clause reads: the digital continuity of the subject shall persist in perpetuity, across all jurisdictions recognising the Hague Digital Persons Convention, without limitation of duration, subject to the ongoing operational capacity of the designated custodial infrastructure.

Olena reads it aloud to herself, very quietly, the way she has always tested language — listening for the place where it gives. It does not give. She wrote it herself, three months ago, at two in the morning with a glass of water going warm on the desk, and she has been testing it since. It holds.

She picks up her pen. Turns to page forty-two. Signs her name in the space provided, then initials the adjacent box, then dates it in the format the registry requires. She does this the way she does everything at the end of a long matter: cleanly, without ceremony.

She sets down the pen.

Outside her window, Kyiv is going about its evening. Tram bells. Someone's music from a window across the courtyard, too faint to identify. The city has been here for fourteen centuries and looks, from this angle, as if it intends to continue indefinitely — which is, Olena thinks, the one aspiration she and her clients hold in common.

She closes the file. Stacks it with the others. Turns off her desk lamp.

On page forty-two, inside a folder inside a cabinet in a law office in Kyiv, someone has just been made permanent.

Olena puts on her coat and goes home.

PART ONE — THE WORLD BEFORE

2025 — 2032

One

The Model and the Person

Olena — 2031

The thing Olena had learned, after three years of upload law, was that clients never asked the question directly. They approached it from the side, circled it, found ways to raise it without raising it, and then looked to her to provide the answer they needed without either of them having acknowledged that the question existed. She had become very skilled at this. She considered it the central competency of her practice.

Tkachenko was doing it now. He was a property developer, sixty-one, the kind of man who had spent four decades turning uncertainty into margin and had recently discovered that death presented a particular challenge to this approach. He sat across her desk in a suit that cost more than most of her associates earned in a month and he said: 'My concern is the continuity of the estate structure across the transition period.'

The transition period. That was one way to put it.

'The Digital Continuity Act resolves this cleanly,' Olena said. 'Post-upload, you retain full legal personhood. Your assets remain yours. There is no transition period in the estate sense because there is no transfer of ownership — you remain the owner, continuously, without interruption.'

'And the children—'

'Cannot contest. There is nothing to contest. You are not dead. You are differently located.'

Tkachenko processed this. She watched him do it — the specific relief of a man who has just been told that the thing he feared most has a contractual solution. It was the expression she saw most often in this office, across this desk, and she had come to understand it the way a doctor comes to understand a symptom: not with feeling, exactly, but with recognition.

'The question people sometimes ask at this point,' she said, 'is whether the uploaded model is legally the same person as the biological original. I want to address that directly so you're not surprised by it later.'

Tkachenko's eyes moved slightly. There it was.

'NeuralMind's process trains a model on the complete electrochemical record of your mind,' Olena said. 'Every memory, every learned association, every cognitive pattern accumulated across your lifetime. The resulting

model is, by every measurable criterion, you. It thinks as you think. It remembers what you remember. It makes decisions the way you make decisions. The law, under the Hague Convention and its Ukrainian implementation, treats this as identity continuity — not a copy, not a simulation, but the same person in a different substrate.' She paused. 'That is what the law says.'

'And what do you say?'

She held his gaze for a moment.

'I say sign on page forty-two.'

* * *

After he left she sat for a while with the signed documents and let herself think about it — the question she had deflected, the one she always deflected, the one she was professionally obligated to answer in one direction and personally uncertain about in another. The model is the person. That was what the law said. That was what her practice depended on.

She thought about the mouse.

She had read about the early trials in 2027 — NeuralMind's internal research, leaked from someone with contacts and a habit of sharing what he probably shouldn't. The paper described a mouse model that navigated a maze the original mouse had learned, making the same wrong turn at junction four that the original always made. Not because the model was imperfect but because the original mouse had always made that wrong turn, because that wrong turn was part of how the original mouse understood the maze, and the model had inherited this understanding completely.

Pattern fidelity intact. Identity markers consistent.

The researchers had written their conclusion and crossed it out and left it without resolution. She had read the paper three times. She had filed it in a folder on her laptop labelled Background — Technical and had not opened the folder since.

She was thinking, as she often thought at this point in a matter, about Roman Bilyk's daughter.

She had not been at the upload itself — the upload was NeuralMind's affair, not hers, she handled the legal architecture before and after — but she had met the daughter twice during the estate proceedings. A woman in her fifties, precise and contained, who had said very little except, once, at the end of the second meeting, whether her father would know her.

Olena had said: yes, of course, the memory record is complete.

The daughter had nodded. She had not looked reassured. She had looked like someone who had received accurate information that did not answer the question she had actually asked.

Olena closed the cabinet. She checked her watch. She had one more hour before she needed to leave.

* * *

The NeuralMind interaction suite occupied the fourth floor of their Kyiv office — rooms designed with the particular care of spaces intended to make the uncanny feel ordinary. Soft lighting. Good furniture. Nothing too cold, nothing too warm, nothing that would remind you of what was happening in the servers one floor below.

Olena visited on behalf of client matters two or three times a month. She had learned to move through the space efficiently — sign in, meet with the relevant uploaded party, take her notes, leave. She did not linger. Lingering made you start to notice things.

Today she had a matter involving TETYANENKO, uploaded two years ago, disputing an asset division with his biological children. He appeared in the interaction room as a rendered presence — photorealistic, seated, wearing what appeared to be the same jacket he had favoured before the upload. He was sixty-eight years old and would be sixty-eight years old indefinitely.

'Ms. Kovalenko.' He looked pleased to see her. He often looked pleased to see her. She thought this might be because she treated him consistently as a person with a legal problem rather than as a phenomenon.

They spent forty minutes on the matter. He was sharp — sharper, perhaps, than before the upload, or perhaps she was noticing it more now. Two years in perpetuity and he had had time to think in ways the biological simply could not sustain. He had read everything he had always meant to read. He had worked through problems he had never had the consecutive hours to fully examine.

She wondered, sometimes, what that was like. She did not allow herself to wonder for long.

'How are your children?' he asked, as she was gathering her notes.

She looked up.

'Fine,' she said. 'Thank you.'

He nodded. Something in his expression — she could not quite read it, and she could usually read everything — suggested that he knew the word fine was doing a great deal of work in that sentence. But he did not press.

She left the way she always left: efficiently, without looking back at the interaction room, without letting herself think about what it would be like to be the one behind the glass instead of the one walking out.

* * *

Home was a fifteen-minute walk from the office when the weather was good, which it was this evening — early autumn, the light going golden over the rooftops, Kyiv in the particular mood it had in September. She walked and let her thinking run without directing it, like water finding its own level.

She was thinking about Tkachenko's question. What do you say? She had deflected it cleanly and professionally. But the truth was that she had been thinking about it for three years, since the first time a client had asked it, and she had not arrived at an answer she fully trusted.

What she believed, on the days when she let herself believe anything, was this: that identity was pattern. That the self was not the body but the particular arrangement of memories and learned responses and accumulated personality that the body housed. That NeuralMind's process captured that pattern with sufficient fidelity that what emerged was, in the only sense that mattered, the same person.

What she believed on the other days was less clear.

She turned into her street. Through the window of the apartment above hers, briefly, the blue flicker of a television. Someone going about their evening, unremarkably alive.

She unlocked the door to her building, climbed the stairs, put her key in the lock.

From inside: piano. Something quiet and unhurried — Andriy at the end of a long day, playing whatever the day needed out of him. She stood for a moment on the landing and listened before turning the key, because there was always a moment, arriving home to the piano, when the rest of it — Tkachenko, Bilyk's daughter, the interaction suite, the question she never answered — receded to a distance she could manage.

She turned the key. Opened the door.

'Mama!'

Maksym, six, launched himself from the kitchen floor, hit her at hip height, and immediately began explaining something at considerable length about a dinosaur he had invented that afternoon. She crouched to his level and gave the dinosaur the attention it deserved. Over his shoulder: Andriy at the piano, watching her with the expression he had when he was glad she was home — quiet, undemonstrative, meaning more than most things people said aloud.

'Borscht,' he said.

'Good,' she said.

She hung up her coat. She was home.

The borscht. The particular smell of it — dill and something deeper underneath. I have been remembering this for longer than I lived.

Two

Some Things Aren't Meant to Last

Andriy — 2031

There was a colleague at the conservatory — PETRO SAVENKO, first violin in the faculty ensemble, a careful and fundamentally decent man — whose wife had uploaded the previous spring. Petro visited the interaction suite every Sunday. He came to rehearsal on Monday mornings with the particular quality of silence that Andriy had come to associate with those visits: not sad exactly, not bereft, but hollowed out in some way that was difficult to name and impossible to address.

Andriy had tried, once, carefully, to ask about it.

'She's exactly the same,' Petro had said, with a precision that suggested he had chosen those words with care. 'She remembers everything. She asks about the children, about rehearsal, about the allotment — she always worried about the allotment, she had very particular feelings about the spacing of the beetroot, and she still does, she has opinions about it. She is completely herself.' He paused. 'I don't know what I'm finding difficult.'

Andriy had thought about this for some time. He thought about it now, sitting at the piano in the quiet apartment, Olena not yet home, Maksym drawing on the floor with his tongue between his teeth in the way he had when concentrating. The television was on in the background — he had turned it on for the news and then forgotten to turn it off, and now there was something about NeuralMind's quarterly results, a graph going upward, a spokeswoman using words like transformative and unprecedented.

He turned it off.

The apartment was better without it. Almost always.

* * *

He had been playing the Ravel this evening — the Pavane Pour une Infante Défunte, which he had been playing since he was nineteen and which meant something different to him every year he returned to it. Tonight it had meant: the beauty of things that end. Which was, he supposed, what it had always meant, since Ravel had written it as a farewell to a dead princess and the title said as much directly. But tonight he felt it rather than simply knowing it.

What he believed about music — had believed since before he could articulate it, since he was a child pressing keys in the draughty apartment where his father had taught him — was that its value was inseparable from

its impermanence. A performance happened once and was gone. You could record it, preserve the notes on paper, but the thing itself — the air moving in a particular room, the particular evening, the particular state of the hands and the mind that played it — that was unrepeatable. That was why it mattered. Because it was happening now and only now and then it was over.

He understood that this was not an original thought. Every musician who had ever played a concert had felt some version of it. But understanding a thing intellectually and knowing it in your hands were different, and he had always known it in his hands.

Petro's wife was exactly the same. She still had opinions about the beetroot spacing.

Andriy thought: but when Petro plays in rehearsal on Monday morning, is she there? When the music happens in that room, is she in it with him?

He did not know how to answer this. He was not certain it was answerable. He sat at the piano and played a bar of the Ravel again and tried to feel whether the impermanence of it was something he was choosing or something that was simply true, and whether there was a difference.

* * *

Maksym came and stood beside the piano bench with the directness of a child who has decided something deserves his full attention.

'Play the bear one,' he said.

The bear one was a Ukrainian folk song Andriy had been teaching him — slow, with a walking bass that Maksym called the bear because it sounded like something large and deliberate moving through a forest. He played it. Maksym listened with his eyes half closed in the way he had when genuinely listening rather than simply present.

'Again,' Maksym said.

He played it again.

'When can I play it?'

'When your hands are bigger. Or sooner, if you're patient.'

'I'm patient,' Maksym said, in the tone of someone for whom this was an aspiration rather than a description.

Andriy almost smiled. He played the opening phrase slowly, hands apart, exaggerating the movement so Maksym could see it.

'The left hand is the bear,' he said. 'The right hand is everything else. They have to agree with each other without being the same. That's what music is, mostly — two things agreeing without being the same.'

Maksym considered this.

'Like you and Mama?'

Andriy looked at his son for a moment.

'Yes,' he said. 'Exactly like that.'

On the floor across the room, in the bassinet they had moved to the living room so she could be near them in the evenings, KRYSTYNA slept with the absolute commitment of a newborn. She had been in the world for eleven weeks. She had already, Andriy thought, the quality of a person who had decided things about herself.

He watched her sleep. He played the bear song again, quietly.

Maksym went back to his drawing.

* * *

A colleague had mentioned the memory enhancement service at a faculty dinner last week — not the full upload, but something NeuralMind was piloting: the ability to capture specific experiences, store them with perfect fidelity, access them on demand. A holiday. A wedding. A child's first steps. The company's language was careful and appealing: preserve what matters most.

Andriy had found this more disturbing than the full upload. He could not immediately explain why. On the drive home Petro had asked what he thought, and Andriy had said: I'm not sure yet, and Petro had nodded as if this were a complete answer, which perhaps it was.

What he thought now, sitting in the quiet apartment: that there was something in the full upload that was at least internally consistent. You were betting that the model was you, that continuity of pattern was continuity of self, and you were either right or wrong and the consequences followed from that. A wager with a clear structure.

But capturing specific experiences — selecting them, preserving them perfectly while the rest wore away — that was deciding which parts of your life were worth keeping. That was deciding that some moments were more real than others. And Andriy, who had spent his professional life in the company of music, which existed only in the moment of its making, found this wrong in a way he could not fully articulate at a dinner table or in a car or possibly anywhere.

He heard Olena's key in the door.

He stayed at the piano. He played the last bar of the Ravel — the descending phrase, the quiet ending, the princess going gently into the distance — and let it resolve.

She appeared in the doorway. Still in her coat. Watching him.

'Long day,' she said.

'Yours too.'

She came in. She kissed him. She smelled of the office — paper and something faintly chemical — and underneath it, her. He held her face for a moment because she sometimes needed to be held still, needed someone to mark the transition between the professional day and the rest of it, and he had learned over twelve years that he was the person for this.

'Borscht,' he said.

'Good,' she said. Her eyes were tired but her face had already started to soften.

He went to the kitchen. She crouched beside Maksym and examined the dinosaur with appropriate seriousness. From the bassinet, Krystyna slept.

The apartment was complete. He thought this simply, without drama: the apartment is complete. He stirred the borscht. He was a man who knew how to be present, and this was one of the things he was most present in — the ordinary, full evening, the family in the same rooms, the steam rising from the pot.

He did not know, then, that he was memorising it. He did not need to know.

Three

The Progression

Olena — 2025–2031

She had heard about the mouse trials in 2027, from a colleague at a conference in Warsaw who had contacts at NeuralMind and a habit of sharing what he probably shouldn't. The research had leaked — a paper that circulated quietly through the legal and scientific communities before NeuralMind's communications team found out about it. Olena had read it in a hotel room in Warsaw at eleven at night and had not slept much afterward.

The paper described, in the careful language of people who understood what they were writing, a mouse model that navigated a maze the original mouse had learned. Making the same wrong turn at junction four. Every time. Not because the model was imperfect but because the original mouse had always made that wrong turn, because that wrong turn was part of how the original mouse understood the maze, and the model had inherited this understanding completely.

Pattern fidelity intact. Identity markers consistent.

She had read the conclusion twice. The researchers had written something and crossed it out and left the page without resolution. She understood why.

* * *

Before the mouse trials — before any of the published research — there had been the pets.

The wealthy had understood before anyone else what the technology could offer, and they had approached it the way the wealthy approach most innovations: quietly, privately, with the resources to be first and the lawyers to ensure that first did not mean exposed. Beginning in 2026, a small number of NeuralMind's private clients had arranged for their animals to be scanned. Dogs, mostly. A few cats. One Arabian horse belonging to a member of a Gulf royal family whose name did not appear in any documentation Olena ever reviewed.

She had heard about this before it became public, through the same Warsaw colleague. What struck her — what she had filed away and returned to several times — was the detail about the border collie.

The collie had belonged to a technology founder based in California. It had died of old age in early 2026 at the age of fourteen, which was a good age for a border collie, and the founder had arranged for a neural scan in the final weeks of the dog's life. The model that resulted, trained on the

complete record of fourteen years of a particular dog's experience, had been placed in a rendered environment and observed. It behaved as the collie had behaved. It responded to the founder's voice. It demonstrated, in the environment, the specific habits the original had developed over fourteen years — the way it circled before lying down, the way it approached strangers, the specific anxiousness it had always shown during thunderstorms.

It had not consented to any of this. This was the detail that the animal rights community had seized on when the story leaked in 2027, and they were not wrong. The dog had been scanned while under anaesthetic for an unrelated procedure in its final weeks. It had not been asked. The question of whether it could have been asked, whether its consent was the kind of thing that could meaningfully be sought, had generated the expected volume of heat and light.

Olena had read the coverage. She had thought about the border collie circling before it lay down. She had not allowed herself to think too long about the corollary question — the one that started with the dog and ended with a human being who also had not, in any meaningful sense, consented to being a model — and she had moved on.

She was very good at moving on.

* * *

The public demonstrations had been more carefully managed. NeuralMind had understood that what the border collie story communicated — accidentally, without their control — was something complex and unsettling that required reframing. They had chosen Otto deliberately: a Labrador from a rescue shelter, unremarkable, chosen to signal that this technology was not only for the extraordinary. The Pavane Pour une Infante Défunte had been Ravel's farewell to a dead princess; NeuralMind's presentation was a farewell to the idea that death was universal.

At the Berlin conference in 2029, Voss had been precise and persuasive. Olena had watched it on a livestream from her office in Kyiv and had thought: she is saying the same thing I say to clients. The model is the person. That is what this argument requires.

Six months later, Roman Bilyk had been first. And then the world had changed, and Olena's practice had changed with it, and she had spent the following two years becoming the best upload lawyer in Kyiv, which was not something she had planned but which had followed, as most things in her life followed, from being exceptionally good at her work and being willing to look at things other people looked away from.

She looked away from some of them. Not all.

* * *

The first client she had represented in a full upload proceeding was HALYNA BONDAR, sixty-seven, retired academic, who had explained her situation with the precision of someone who had thought about it for a long time. She was healthy. She was not afraid of death in the ordinary sense. She had simply looked at the technology and concluded that it was available and that she wanted to use it, and she found the philosophical objections less compelling than the practical opportunity.

Olena had handled the estate work, the personhood filings, the continuity contract. The upload had happened on a Thursday in March. On Friday, Halyna's daughter had called about the inherited asset structure.

The conversation had been entirely procedural. At the end of it the daughter said: 'She called me this morning. From the suite. She wanted to know how the defence was going.' The daughter was an academic like her mother, working on a dissertation. Halyna had been following its progress for three years. She was still following it.

'That's good,' Olena had said, carefully.

'Yes,' the daughter said. And then, after a pause perhaps two seconds longer than a purely procedural pause: 'It's very good.'

Olena completed the call. She sat for a moment. She thought about what the daughter's voice had contained in those two seconds — relief and grief and something that was neither, something more complex — and she put it in the folder and closed the folder and opened the next file.

* * *

Krystyna had arrived in January of 2032 on a Tuesday evening, impatient and definite, as if she had somewhere to be. At the end of fourteen hours Olena had lain back with her daughter on her chest and felt the specific depletion and fullness of someone who has done something enormous and is not yet capable of processing it.

Andriy had held her before Olena did. The nurse placed Krystyna in his arms and Olena watched his face — watched him receive his daughter — and thought: there it is. She had seen that expression once before, with Maksym, and still had no name for it. The expression of a person encountering something larger than themselves and choosing, without reservation, to let it in.

He looked at Olena over Krystyna's head.

'She looks like herself,' he said.

She did. Already, in the first minutes of her life, Krystyna had the quality of someone with a settled opinion of things.

Olena had three months of maternity leave. She used six weeks and went back, because she was not someone comfortable being still, and because the work needed her, and because she had long understood that she was a better mother when she was also the other things she was. Andriy

did not say anything about this. He had always understood the parts of her that were not immediately legible.

The apartment was different with Krystyna in it — fuller, louder, more itself. Maksym was suspicious at first and then, in the way of older siblings, decided proprietary. He watched his sister with the intensity of someone taking inventory. He would stand at the edge of her bassinet and report on her activities to whoever was nearby.

Andriy played for her from the beginning. Whatever he was practising, she was in the room. The music was simply part of the air she breathed.

This was, Olena thought sometimes, the best thing about being their child. They grew up understanding that music was not special. It was ordinary. It was what happened in the evenings and on Sunday mornings and when something needed working out. Not an event within the family — the atmosphere of it.

She thought about what she was giving them. She thought about this more than was probably useful — perhaps an occupational hazard, for someone who spent her days managing the structures that protect things. She was giving them a stable home, a good school, the best of what she could provide.

She was not giving them what Tkachenko's children would have. She was not giving them what Halyna Bondar's daughter had.

She tried not to think about this. She went home. She hung up her coat. The piano was playing.

> *He played for her from the beginning. She was always in the room. I don't remember a time before the music — it was simply part of the air, which means it is part of me, which means it is the most permanent thing I have.*

Four

Krystyna

Andriy — January 2032

He had forgotten, in the four years since Maksym, how specific it was.

Not the general experience of new fatherhood — the exhaustion and the fear and the love that arrived before you were ready for it — but the specific person. He had forgotten how immediately each child was themselves. Maksym had arrived with his particular intensity already in place, his jaw set even as a newborn, his eyes tracking the room with suspicious intelligence. And now Krystyna had arrived and she was entirely different — not more or less than Maksym, but different in the way that two notes in the same key are different, the same structure but a different sound.

She looked at him with eyes that were still trying to focus and would not properly do so for some weeks, and yet he had the distinct impression of being regarded. Of being assessed.

'Hello, Krystyna,' he said. He was aware that he was whispering, though there was no particular reason to whisper. The room was quiet and the nurses had withdrawn and Olena was sleeping finally, exhausted, and it was just him and his daughter in the lamplight of a Tuesday night in January.

She made a sound. He adjusted his hold. She was so small. He was always surprised, each time, by how small they were — as if the size of the feeling they generated should correspond to a larger physical form.

He sat with her for a long time. He was not a man given to formal declarations or private ceremonies, but he made, sitting in that chair in the maternity ward while Kyiv went about its night outside, a promise he did not say aloud. He did not say it aloud because saying it would have required words, and the words available were insufficient to the thing he was promising, which was simply: I will be here. Whatever comes. I will be here.

He had made the same promise to Maksym, four years earlier, in a different room. He had kept it. He intended to keep this one too.

* * *

Maksym was brought in the next morning by Olena's mother — sharp, seventy, retired, helpful without being present more than necessary. She set Maksym down in the doorway and he stood there for a moment, taking in the scene with his characteristic inventory expression, and then walked directly to Andriy and said: 'Can I see her?'

Andriy held her out. Maksym looked at his sister with such concentrated attention that Andriy had to work to keep his expression neutral.

'She's small,' Maksym said.

'You were too.'

'I was bigger.'

'You were not.'

'I was probably bigger,' Maksym said, with the confidence of someone who understood that he could not be immediately disproven. He reached out one finger and Krystyna, responding to some ancient reflex, gripped it.

Maksym looked up.

'She grabbed me.'

'Yes.'

'She knew it was me?'

Andriy considered. 'She knew it was a person,' he said. 'That's enough for now.'

Maksym looked at his sister again, at his finger in her grip, with an expression Andriy had not seen on him before. Proprietorial was the closest word, but that was not quite it. More like: staking a claim. More like: deciding.

Olena, from the bed, watched all of this without saying anything. When Andriy looked at her she had the expression she almost never allowed herself — unguarded, completely present, not analysing or managing, just there. He held it in his mind the way you hold a note about to resolve.

* * *

He took Krystyna home on a Friday, in a car seat that seemed comically large for her, with Olena beside him in the back checking her every forty seconds and Maksym in the front providing a running commentary on the traffic. The apartment received them. It had been reconfigured slightly in the weeks before — the bassinet in the living room, new hooks by the door — but it was still the apartment, still the piano and the bookshelves and the smell of the place, and he felt, carrying Krystyna through the door for the first time, that she was arriving somewhere that already belonged to her.

He set her in the bassinet. She looked at the ceiling.

Maksym looked at the ceiling too, trying to see what she was seeing.

Andriy sat at the piano. Olena was on the couch with her phone — there were always emails — and Maksym was lying on his stomach on the floor studying his sister's face with scientific attention. The apartment was full.

He played one-handed — his right hand, slowly, the beginning of the Pavane. The Ravel. He had been playing it since he was nineteen and it had meant, over the years, many things. Today it meant: hello. Today it meant: welcome.

Krystyna's eyes moved. Not toward the sound — she could not yet locate sound that precisely — but in a way that suggested the sound had reached her. That it was part of what the world was, for her, from this first day.

He played it through. Slowly, with his right hand, the melody bare without its harmonies but the shape of it there. Maksym listened without moving. Olena set down her phone.

The apartment was complete.

He did not know, then, that he was memorising it. He did not need to know. Some things are stored without intention, laid down in the body before the mind has decided whether to keep them.

He played on.

BILLABLE PERPETUITY

A Novel

Part Two · First Draft · 2025

PART TWO — THE ORDINARY LIFE

2032 — 2035

Five

Adjusted

Olena — 2033

The word she always used was adjusted. Families of the uploaded adjusted. It was the right word — neutral, clinical, carrying no judgment about the direction or adequacy of the adjustment, simply acknowledging that adjustment was what the situation required and that the situation was, by any reasonable assessment, adjustable. She had used it in consultations, in court filings, in the paper she had given at a conference in Vienna the previous autumn on the psychological and legal dimensions of post-upload family structures. Adjusted. The families adjusted.

She used it again now, sitting across from MRS. YAROVA in the third meeting of what had become a protracted matter. Yarova was seventy-one, composed, the kind of woman who had arranged her life with considerable care and found it disquieting when reality failed to honour the arrangement. Her children had not adjusted.

'My daughter in London hasn't spoken to me in four months,' Yarova said. She said it the way she said most things: matter-of-factly, as if reporting on a situation that involved someone else. Olena had learned that this was one of the ways people managed things that were not manageable. You described them in the third person. You adopted the tone of a disinterested observer. It helped, for a time.

'That's not uncommon,' Olena said.

'She says it isn't me.' Yarova paused. 'She says the model isn't me. That what she's speaking to isn't her mother but a very convincing—' she chose the word carefully '—simulation. Her therapist has told her that her grief is legitimate. That she is allowed to mourn.' Yarova's composure did not crack, but something around its edges shifted. 'As if I were dead.'

Olena said nothing for a moment. She had learned that there were times when saying nothing was the most useful thing she could offer.

'Your daughter's position is not legally relevant to your personhood status or your asset rights,' she said eventually. 'But I understand it is personally—'

'I want to know,' Yarova said, 'whether there is any legal mechanism by which I could require her to accept the situation.'

'No.'

'None at all.'

'None. The law protects your personhood and your rights. It cannot compel a relationship.'

Yarova looked at her hands. She had the hands of someone who had done a great deal — well-maintained but marked by use. The rendered hands. Olena had noticed, in her visits to the interaction suite, that the uploaded often looked at their rendered hands. She had never asked any of them what they were thinking when they did it.

'Adjusted,' Yarova said. 'You said the families adjust.'

'Most do.'

'And the ones that don't?'

Olena held her gaze. 'They find their own way,' she said. 'Eventually.'

It was not a satisfying answer. It was the truest one she had.

* * *

She visited Tetyanenko that afternoon — a property dispute complicated by his elder son's increasingly creative interpretations of their pre-upload agreement. Tetyanenko had been in perpetuity for just over two years. He was, as he had always been, precise and slightly combative in a way Olena found professionally comfortable: he told her exactly what he wanted, accepted exactly what was possible, and did not waste either of their time on the space in between.

He had changed, though. Over her visits she had noticed it and thought about how to describe it, and the best she had arrived at was: he had become more himself. The aspects of his personality that had always been most distinctly his — the sharpness, the pleasure in argument, the wide-ranging curiosity that sat slightly at odds with his background in property development — had intensified. As if perpetuity had stripped away the noise and left the signal clearer.

She was not certain this was a good thing. She noted it.

'My son's lawyer is very good,' Tetyanenko said, with what sounded like genuine appreciation.

'Your son's lawyer is adequate,' Olena said. 'The argument he's making has three structural weaknesses. I've addressed them in the response.'

She walked him through it. He listened with complete attention — another thing she had noticed, in the uploaded, was the quality of their attention. Without the ambient background of the biological — the tiredness, the hunger, the thousand small physical demands — they were present in conversation in a way the biological rarely managed. Enviable, or alarming. She had not decided which.

At the end of the meeting he said, as he sometimes did: 'How are your children?'

'Well. Krystyna is walking now. Maksym has opinions about everything.'

'That's the age,' he said.

She thought: you had children. Biological children, grown, who were now attending the meetings she had described to Yarova. She thought: you know exactly what that age is like and you are going to know it forever, in the way of a record played on an endless loop — preserved, complete, never arriving at the place where it simply stops.

She gathered her notes. She said goodbye. She walked out of the interaction suite and took a breath and put it all in the folder.

* * *

Home that evening: Krystyna, fourteen months, had developed what Andriy called conducting. She stood at the edge of the coffee table when he played, holding on with one hand, and moved the other through the air in a way that was entirely her own — not imitating his hands but doing something parallel, something that suggested she understood the sound was being made by a person and that a person doing a thing could be responded to.

Maksym found this objectionable.

'She's not conducting. She doesn't know what conducting is.'

'She's doing what conducting does,' Andriy said. 'That's near enough.'

'It's not the same.'

'Most things aren't the same as their names. That doesn't make them less real.'

Maksym considered this, decided it was unsatisfying, and went back to his drawing. Krystyna continued. Andriy played the bear song because she seemed to respond to it more than to anything else — something in the bass register she found compelling.

Olena sat on the couch with the Yarova file and watched her family. She thought about Yarova's hands. She thought about what Yarova's daughter in London would give to be in this room right now — the ordinary room, the unremarkable Tuesday evening, the family going about itself.

She thought: I have this. I have this exactly.

She thought: it is not guaranteed.

She put the file away. She went and sat on the floor beside Krystyna, who immediately grabbed her finger with both hands and said something that was not yet a word but had the structure of one — the insistence of one.

'I know,' Olena said. 'I know.'

* * *

The conversation about Bohdan happened in October, at dinner, arriving through the side door of an ordinary evening.

Maksym had been at school with Bohdan since the beginning of the year. Bohdan's father was scheduled to upload in the spring, which Bohdan had communicated to his classmates with the specific pride of a child who has recently learned that his family has something other families don't. This information had been circulating for some weeks and had now arrived at their dinner table.

'Bohdan says his father will never die,' Maksym said, with the directness of a child who has not yet learned to approach things sideways. 'He says he'll always have a father. He says it's not fair that other people's fathers will die and his won't.'

Andriy said: 'Maksym.'

The word was quiet. It had a floor in it that Maksym recognised — not anger, but something underneath anger, a depth that communicated: we are not going to go further in this direction tonight. Maksym understood this floor when he encountered it and generally respected it.

'Eat your dinner,' Andriy said.

Maksym ate. Krystyna, in her high chair, was eating with both hands and the systematic focus of someone who considers food a serious project. Neither Olena nor Andriy looked at each other.

Later, after the children were in bed, Andriy stood at the piano without playing. Olena was at the kitchen table with a glass of wine and the Yarova response. The apartment was quiet in the way it was quiet after the children were asleep — a full quiet, not an empty one.

'He's going to keep asking,' Andriy said.

'I know.'

'What do we tell him?'

She looked up from the document. 'The truth. We can't afford it. Most people can't. That's the world.'

'And that's sufficient? That's simply the world, so—'

'Andriy.'

He turned from the piano. He was not angry — he was something more considered than angry, the expression of a man who has been thinking about something for a long time and has decided to say part of it.

'You spend your days making it available for people like Bohdan's father,' he said. 'You write the contracts. You sit across from them and you make it possible. And then you come home to this.' He stopped. 'I'm not accusing you of anything. I know why you do it. I know what it provides. I'm asking whether you ever think about the distance between those two rooms.'

She thought about Yarova's hands. She thought about Bilyk's daughter pressing her palm against the glass. She thought about Tetyanenko, sharper and more entirely himself with every visit, accumulating time in a way she could not.

'I think about it,' she said.

'And?'

'And I go back to work in the morning. Because that's what I know how to do. And because the alternative—'

She did not finish the sentence. She was not certain what the alternative was. She was not certain she wanted to be certain.

Andriy looked at her for a moment. Then he sat at the piano and played — not the Ravel, something else, something in a minor key that moved through the apartment like weather. She returned to the Yarova response. The apartment held them, separately and together.

> *They talked about it that night. I know they did because I have the memory of lying in my room listening to their voices — too low to make out words, but the shape of a serious conversation, the particular rhythm of two people working something out. I did not know what they were working out. I was fourteen months old and the voices were simply the sound the apartment made when they were both in it, which was the sound of everything being all right.*

Six

Breathe

Andriy — 2034

The lesson had been going badly for twenty minutes before Maksym found it.

He was eight now — old enough to be self-conscious about mistakes, young enough not to have developed the patience that self-consciousness required. He had been playing the folk melody for three weeks, long enough to be past basic hesitation, and yet he kept catching at the third phrase as if surprised by it, even though he had played it dozens of times and the phrase did not change.

'Stop,' Andriy said. 'What happens before the third phrase?'

Maksym played the second phrase.

'And after it?'

He played the fourth.

'So you know the third phrase is coming. You've played it correctly fourteen times this session. Why do you keep catching at it?'

Maksym looked at his hands. 'I don't know.'

'Yes you do.'

A long pause. Andriy waited. He had learned, over years of teaching, that the pause was often the lesson. The student who could sit with not-knowing long enough to find what was underneath it was already most of the way to understanding.

'I'm listening to myself play it,' Maksym said finally. 'While I'm playing it. And then I make a mistake because I'm listening instead of playing.'

'Yes,' Andriy said.

'So how do I stop listening?'

'You don't stop listening. You listen differently. There's a part of you that monitors what you're doing and a part of you that does it. When you play well, the doing part is in front. When you play badly, the monitoring part has taken over. The monitoring part doesn't trust the doing part.' Andriy played the phrase — cleanly, without hesitation. 'The doing part learned this weeks ago. It knows the phrase. You have to let it play.'

Maksym tried again. The hesitation was still there, slightly.

'Breathe first,' Andriy said. 'Before the phrase. Give yourself a breath.'

Maksym breathed. Played. The phrase came out clean — not perfect, but uninterrupted. The doing part briefly in front.

'There,' Andriy said. 'That.'

Maksym played it again. Again. Building the path.

* * *

On the floor nearby, KRYSTYNA, two, sat with her toy keyboard — eight plastic keys in primary colours, a birthday gift from Olena's mother that had already been through considerable use. She pressed the keys one at a time with the flat of her finger, listening to each note before pressing the next, with the methodical attention she brought to most things.

She had been doing this for weeks. Not playing songs — playing notes, exploring the instrument in the way a child explores any object: systematically, with complete seriousness, learning what it was before deciding what to do with it.

He watched her between phrases of Maksym's lesson. She pressed a note. Listened. Pressed the next. She had been on the same sequence of four notes for several minutes, going back and forth between them.

'Krystyno,' he said. 'Come here.'

She came, carrying the toy keyboard, which he had not anticipated.

He lifted her onto the piano bench beside him. She was very small on it — her legs stuck straight out, not reaching the floor. She set the toy keyboard on her lap with great care.

'These are the same,' he said. He played four notes on the piano: C, D, E, F. Then played them on her keyboard. She watched with complete attention.

'They sound different,' she said.

'Different instrument. Same notes.'

She considered this. Then played C, D, E, F on her keyboard. Then on the piano, stretching to reach, her small hand spanning the distance.

'Same,' she said, satisfied.

'Same,' he agreed.

Maksym, from across the room: 'She can't play.'

'She's learning what playing is,' Andriy said. 'That comes before playing.'

'How long does it take?'

'Different for everyone. For you, about six months before you were playing anything I'd call a song. For her—' He looked at Krystyna, back to pressing single notes with absolute concentration. 'Hard to say. She has her own pace.'

'What if she's better than me?'

The question arrived with the directness Maksym always brought to things he cared about — stripped of protective indirection.

'Then she's better than you,' Andriy said. 'And you'll still be you, and she'll still be her, and music is large enough for both of you.'

Maksym processed this. Then: 'Play the bear song.'

Andriy played the bear song. Krystyna moved her hands above the toy keyboard in the way she had. Maksym sat on the floor and listened.

It was an adequate afternoon. More than adequate.

* * *

The faculty dinner was in November, at the conservatory director's apartment. Twelve of them around a long table, the usual mixture of performers and administrators, the usual careful texture of institutional social life.

The conversation moved, as it always moved these days, to NeuralMind. The company had announced a new service: the ability to archive the complete neural record of a living person and hold it in storage, a kind of insurance policy. You did not upload. You did not become a digital entity. You simply ensured that if you died, the option remained open — the record was there, the decision could be made retroactively by designated family members on your behalf.

'It's essentially a policy that says your family can decide to resurrect you,' said the director.

'Or can decide not to,' said someone else. 'It only moves the decision.'

'The question is whether a decision made by your family, about your consciousness, after your death, constitutes consent,' Petro Savenko said. He had been to the interaction suite that morning and had the Monday-morning quality about him — the hollowed patience.

'Consent to not-die seems like it should be at least as coherent as consent to die,' Andriy said.

'Consent to not-die given by someone who is already dead seems like it should be less coherent,' Petro said, with a precision that ended that branch of the conversation.

Andriy drove home thinking about the archive service. He found himself — unusually — uncertain about his own position. Not uncertain about whether he wanted it for himself: he did not, clearly, viscerally. But uncertain about whether his position was a belief or a preference, and whether there was a difference.

He asked Olena about it when he got home. She was awake, reading, the lamp on her side of the bed the only light.

'It's a product,' she said. 'Like any product.'

'That's not what I asked.'

She looked up. 'I know.' A pause. 'I think it's probably the service that gets the most people into the ecosystem who would otherwise have been reluctant. The archive makes you feel like you're keeping options open rather than making a commitment. Most people find options preferable to commitments, even when the options lead to the same place.'

'Still not what I asked.'

'I know,' she said again. She turned off her lamp. 'I don't know what I think about it. That's an honest answer.'

It was. He turned off his lamp. Through the wall, Krystyna breathing — the steady, committed breathing of a sleeping child.

He thought about the archive service. He thought about the bear song and the phrase that needed a breath before it. He thought about how

entirely and simply he did not want a world in which whether his children continued was something that could be resolved by a product.

He thought this and knew it was not a complete answer.

He slept.

* * *

In the spring of 2034, Krystyna learned her first song.

It took six weeks of irregular effort. She came to the piano when she wanted to — not every day — and worked at it without visible frustration at mistakes and without the performing-progress quality Maksym had brought to his early lessons. She simply did the thing until it worked.

The song was a simple Ukrainian lullaby Andriy had played for her when she was very small. She had chosen it herself — heard him play it one morning and said: teach me that one, with the specific finality of someone who has considered the options and decided.

He taught her, one phrase at a time, over six weeks. She pressed each key with the flat of her finger, her hand not yet shaped to the keys. The melody emerged slowly, unevenly, but unmistakably.

The morning she played it through without stopping, Maksym was at school. Olena was at work. It was just the two of them.

She played it from beginning to end with complete concentration and then looked at him.

'I did it,' she said.

'You did it.'

'Again?'

'Again.'

She played it again. And again. Each time a little more her own — the phrasing beginning to develop, the slight variations that came from a person rather than a machine. He sat beside her and listened and thought: this is the beginning of something. Whatever she becomes, this is one of the first stones of it.

She looked up after the fourth repetition. 'What's the next one?'

He played a bar of something — a simple folk dance, more rhythmic, a different challenge. She listened twice.

'That one,' she said.

He began to teach her.

The lullaby. I can hear it perfectly — every note, every hesitation, the phrase I kept getting wrong in the fourth bar, the morning I finally got it right. I played it four times. Papa sat beside me and didn't say much. He didn't need to. I knew what it meant. You know, with him, because of the quality of his listening. When he is listening like that, you know you've done something real.

Seven

The Last Normal Morning

Olena — February 2035

She remembered, afterward, that she had been reading a contract clause about force majeure.

Not the NeuralMind contracts — a more ordinary matter, a commercial lease dispute. Force majeure: unforeseeable circumstances that prevent someone from fulfilling a contract. Acts of God, in the older language. Events outside the reasonable scope of planning.

She had been thinking about whether the clause as drafted was sufficiently specific when the phone rang. She let it go to the third ring, finishing the sentence she was reading, because she was always finishing sentences before answering. This was a habit her assistant had adapted to. Most people in her life had adapted to it. It did not matter, most of the time, those extra two rings.

She picked up.

* * *

The morning had been ordinary in every detail she could later reconstruct.

Andriy had made porridge — a Tuesday food, by Maksym's classification. Krystyna had eaten hers with systematic focus and then wanted down from her chair to investigate the pigeons on the sill. Maksym had complained about his hat. Andriy had insisted. The hat had been retrieved and worn with the expression of a person being profoundly wronged.

'Drive carefully,' she had said to Andriy, without looking up from the brief she had opened over breakfast. She said it most mornings, automatically, the way you said things that had become reflex — not because she was worried specifically, but because it was the kind of thing you said to the people you loved as they went into the world. A small ritual. An unspoken contract between the morning and the rest of the day.

'Always,' he had said.

The door had closed. Krystyna had toddled back from the window with information about the pigeons. Olena had listened with appropriate attention, finished her coffee, put on her coat.

She had gone to work. She had opened the force majeure clause.

Unforeseeable circumstances.

* * *

She did not remember the drive to the hospital. She knew she had taken a taxi — she found, two weeks later, the charge on her bank statement — but she had no memory of getting into it or of what she had thought during the journey. She remembered: her office, the phone, a voice, and then the corridor.

The corridor on the third floor of Kyiv Central, which smelled of antiseptic and something faintly floral from a cleaning product. She noticed this with the strange precision that shock sometimes brought — the way details became vivid at the expense of the larger picture. Antiseptic. Something floral. Fluorescent lights, slightly blue.

She turned the corner.

Andriy was sitting in a plastic chair with his head in his hands. His left forearm had a bandage on it — white, clean, suggesting something minor had been attended to. He was otherwise, as far as she could see, unhurt. Essentially unhurt.

She stopped.

The thing about being a lawyer was that you learned to read situations before you had all the information. You learned to understand what a room was telling you before anyone spoke. She had been very good at this for a long time, and she was very good at it now, standing in the corridor, reading Andriy's posture and the bandage on his arm and the absence of Maksym anywhere in her field of vision.

She knew before she reached him. She had known from the phone call, probably — the knowledge sitting in the body before the mind was ready to receive it.

She crossed the corridor. She sat in the chair beside him.

He looked up. His face.

She took his hand.

She did not ask what had happened. She already knew. The asking could come later — the facts assembled, the sequence established, the inquest completed. None of that was necessary right now. Right now there was only this: his hand in hers, the fluorescent light, the smell of antiseptic and something floral, the corridor that had divided itself into before and after.

They sat.

* * *

The weeks that followed had the quality, she thought later, of a very long administrative task. There were things that needed to be done and she did them. Forms. Calls. Arrangements. The specific bureaucracy of death, which was extensive and unsparing, which demanded that grief be set aside long enough to sign things and respond to people whose kindness was genuine and whose presence was nonetheless exhausting.

She was good at this. She had always been good at the management of difficult things. She understood that this was not the same as being all right, and that management was a way of deferring what would come later, and that the later was getting closer every day.

Andriy did not speak much. She did not try to make him. He had gone somewhere she could not follow — not away from her but into himself, into the geography of something she could not map because it was his and not hers. She gave him room. She understood, without either of them having to say it, that they were each doing what they needed to do, and that different did not mean wrong.

She did not go to the piano. He had closed the lid. The Ravel was still on the stand. She did not close the Ravel. Some instinct about not disturbing things that had been placed.

One evening, two weeks in, after Krystyna was asleep and the apartment was quiet, she sat at her desk and opened her laptop. She opened a browser window. She typed: posthumous upload minor Ukraine law feasibility.

She read for two hours. Technical literature, legal literature, NeuralMind documentation, academic papers, policy arguments. She read the section on neural record integrity for posthumous scans, which explained, in careful technical language, that fidelity degraded rapidly after biological death, that the window for a scan capable of producing a model of sufficient integrity was measured in hours rather than days, that the technology existed in principle but not in practice for cases where the scan had not been initiated prior to death.

She read it twice.

She closed the laptop.

She sat in the dark for a while. Then she got up and checked on Krystyna, who was sleeping with the absolute commitment of a three-year-old, one arm thrown out, VOVK the rabbit tucked under the other.

Olena stood in the doorway for a long time.

Then she went to bed.

The smell of that corridor. Antiseptic and something floral underneath. I have been remembering it for longer than I lived. I have been trying to understand what it means that I remember it at all — that the corridor my mother walked down on that afternoon is inside me, encoded with perfect fidelity, part of what I am. I think it means she carried it with her. I think it means I have everything she carried.

Eight

Tuesday

Andriy — 2035–2037

He did not remember the impact.

He remembered the light — the February light at that intersection, pale and slightly sideways, the kind that made you squint in the mornings. He remembered Maksym asking about the dog. He remembered almost smiling. He remembered the light turning green.

Then the sound.

Then nothing, for a period he could not subsequently measure, until he was aware of the steering wheel under his hands and a noise that was the car's horn, which he was not pressing but which was sounding anyway, and the stillness.

He did not look to his right for a long time. He knew. In the way that the body sometimes knows things before the mind is ready, he knew, and his body held him very still and did not let him look because it understood that looking would make it real in a way that not-looking was not yet ready to complete.

When he looked, the seat was empty.

Someone was at the window. A voice: are you all right, are you hurt. His left arm hurt. He could not identify, in the geometry of what had happened, how his left arm had been hurt. It seemed, in the context of everything, not very important.

He said something. He did not know what.

The rest arrived piece by piece, over hours and days and months and years, in the way that certain things arrive — not all at once but incrementally, each piece being received at the moment the capacity to receive it existed.

* * *

The first month was the worst in a specific way. He was present in his body — he went to places, he said things, he responded to people — but the presence had a thin quality, as if he were standing just behind himself, watching from a short distance.

Olena managed things. He understood that she was managing things and was grateful in a way he could not express, because expression required energy that was not available.

Krystyna did not understand. She was three. She knew something had changed — children that age understood change in the body of the household before they understood it conceptually — and she responded with

the specific clinging that was her way of seeking reassurance, climbing onto him whenever he sat somewhere accessible, pressing her face against his neck. He held her. Holding her was one of the things he could do. It did not require the energy that expression required.

He did not go near the piano. This was not a decision he made. He simply did not go near it. The piano had always been where he put things — the residue of the day, the grief and the joy and the ordinary texture of being alive. He understood, without examining it directly, that if he went near the piano now he would have to put this in it, and he was not ready.

He was not certain he would ever be ready.

The Ravel stayed on the stand. Olena had not moved it. He had noticed this and said nothing about it, but he was grateful.

* * *

One morning — he thought it was March, six weeks in — Krystyna climbed onto the piano bench. He was in the kitchen. He heard the bench creak, and then, after a moment, a single note.

It rang out in the apartment and then faded.

He stood very still at the kitchen counter with his hands on the edge of it. The note — he could identify it even through the wall — was C. The C above middle C. No particular significance. Simply a three-year-old pressing a key.

He left the kitchen. He went into the bedroom and sat on the edge of the bed.

He heard her press another key. D. Then back to C. She was exploring in the way she always explored things — methodically, without hurry. She did not know what she had started. She did not know that the note had gone through him like something physical.

He sat on the edge of the bed for a long time. From the living room, intermittently, C and D and E, Krystyna conducting her research.

He thought about Maksym. He thought about the Tuesday morning. He thought about the particular quality of the February light.

He thought about the dog that Maksym had been about to ask for, the answer he had been about to give, the fraction of a second between the almost-smile and the sound.

He sat on the bed. He breathed. He thought: I should go back in there and sit with her. He thought this and did not move.

After a while the notes stopped. He heard her climb down — the thump of small feet — and go toward the window where the pigeons were. He got up. He went back to the kitchen. He made lunch.

* * *

He returned to teaching in April. Not performing — he had a concert in March that he cancelled and did not reschedule — but teaching, because the conservatory needed him and because being with students required a different kind of presence than being with himself. Students needed instruction. Instruction had a structure. Structure was, in that period, the most valuable thing he knew.

Petro was kind in the way that people who understood loss were kind — not effusive, not insistent, simply present. He brought coffee to Andriy's studio on Monday mornings and said very little and played his violin in the next room where Andriy could hear it. This was a form of care that Petro had developed through his own experience of something similar, and Andriy accepted it as such.

He did not talk about it at work. Not only repression — also the understanding that the appropriate container for this was not the conservatory but wherever Olena was. Whatever they were building together in the apartment, in the evenings, in the silence they were learning to share.

She had gone back to work immediately. He had not, at first, understood this. He had felt something at the edge of resentment — how could she, how was it possible. And then he had watched her over weeks and understood: the work was not what she was doing instead of grieving. The work was how she was keeping herself upright long enough to grieve in whatever way she was capable of grieving, and that way was her own and not his, and his was not hers, and they were each doing the only thing they could do.

He went back to teaching. He came home. He did not play.

* * *

In September — seven months after the Tuesday — he lifted the piano lid.

He did not plan to. He was passing, and his hand was there, and he lifted it. The keys were exactly as they had always been: eighty-eight of them, black and white, the accumulated weight of thirty years.

He sat down. He looked at the keys for a long time.

He played one note. Middle C. Let it ring and fade. He played the note beside it. D. Let it ring. He played them together. The interval. He sat with it.

Then he closed the lid.

He did this for three weeks. Sitting at the piano, playing a note or two, sitting with whatever arrived, closing the lid. Not phrases, not songs, not the Ravel. He was learning the instrument again, from the beginning, the way you learn something you have been away from — respectfully, without assumptions.

The night he first played a complete phrase — four bars of something, his hands choosing it without him — Olena was in the kitchen. He heard her stop moving. The sounds of her evening paused.

He played the phrase again. Then stopped.

She appeared in the doorway. She did not say anything. She leaned against the frame and looked at him — not studying, not worried, just present. Just there.

He played the phrase a third time. Then a fourth, with a small variation. Then something adjacent to it, exploratory.

'Don't stop,' she said. Very quietly.

He did not stop.

He played for half an hour, finding things rather than making them — music emerging the way water found channels. He was rusty. He missed notes. He did not care about the missed notes. He was, for the first time in seven months, doing the thing that was most essentially his — not performing it, not demonstrating it, but doing it, in the privacy of the apartment, with no witness but Olena in the doorway and Krystyna asleep in the other room.

When he stopped she was still there.

He turned to look at her. She looked back. Neither of them said anything. There was nothing that needed saying. Some things passed between them in the silence that was not silence — the apartment's particular sound, his hands still on the keys, the Ravel still on the stand — and whatever passed was sufficient.

He closed the lid gently, the way you closed something you intended to open again.

* * *

By 2037 they had found the shape of a different life. Not a lesser life — not the old one with something removed, which was how he had feared it would be — but a different one, built around a different geography. The absence of Maksym was not a hole in the map. It was part of the map. It was the river the rest of the landscape organised itself around.

Krystyna was five, and she was herself in a way that astonished him regularly: definite, curious, possessed of opinions that arrived without warning and with considerable force. She had her own relationship with the piano now — not his, not inherited, not a tribute. Hers. She came to it when she wanted to, played the lullaby she had learned and the folk dance she was still learning and combinations of notes that were not songs but were not nothing either.

She asked about Maksym one morning in the spring, over breakfast, with the directness of a child who had been thinking about it for some time and had decided this was the moment.

'Who is Maksym?' She had seen the photograph on the refrigerator.

'Your brother,' he said.

'Where is he?'

'He died. Before you were old enough to remember.'

'Oh.' She looked at her bowl. Then: 'Does he know about me?'

He looked at his daughter. The question had a specific quality — not sad, not afraid, genuinely curious — the question of someone who needed to know that she had been known, that her existence had been witnessed by the person in the photograph.

'Yes,' he said. 'He knew about you.'

It was true. Maksym had known about Krystyna before she arrived — had been told, had watched the preparations, had claimed her with a finger-grip in a hospital room. He had known about her.

'Good,' she said. And went back to her porridge.

He stood at the stove for a moment afterward, spatula in hand. He thought: she needed to know she had been real to someone who was no longer here to say so. He had told her she was. That was, in the end, what he needed too. To know that Maksym had been real. Not preserved. Not continued. Real, and then gone, and real in a way that did not require continuing to be real.

He turned back to the stove. He made breakfast. The photograph on the refrigerator looked out at the room with the gap-toothed smile of a boy who had known about his sister and would always have known, in the only tense that mattered.

BILLABLE PERPETUITY

A Novel

Part Three · First Draft · 2025

PART THREE — THE DIAGNOSIS

2038 — 2039

Nine

The Number

Olena — Spring 2038

DR. IRYNA HRYTSENKO had the office of someone who had thought carefully about how rooms should receive bad news. The walls were a warm grey, not clinical white. The chairs were upholstered. There was a window with a view of trees rather than of the hospital's service entrance. There was a box of tissues on the corner of the desk, positioned with the specific discretion of something meant to be available without being conspicuous.

Olena noticed all of this in the first thirty seconds. She noticed things quickly, and she had learned to let noticing be a form of management — something to do with the mind while the mind was receiving information it was not yet ready to process.

'The biopsy results confirm what we saw on the imaging,' Dr. Hrytsenko said. She was fifty, precise, with the quality of someone who had delivered a great many bad results and had not become inured to it but had developed a specific gravity around the work. 'It's lymphoma. Hodgkin's, stage two. Serious, but treatable. We caught it early enough that our protocol has very good outcomes.'

Beside her, Andriy was very still.

'What is the treatment?' he said.

'ABVD chemotherapy. Four cycles, possibly six. We'll reassess after the second. Most children her age respond well. She could be in remission within eight months.'

'And if she doesn't respond?'

'We have second-line options. Escalated protocols. It's too early to—'

'What are the survival statistics for non-response?' Olena said.

Dr. Hrytsenko looked at her.

'Mrs. Kovalenko—'

'I want the number.'

A pause. The kind in which a doctor assessed what kind of person she was dealing with and made a decision about what that person needed.

'For refractory Hodgkin's in children Krystyna's age,' Dr. Hrytsenko said carefully, 'roughly thirty percent five-year survival without escalation to transplant.'

Silence.

'And with transplant?'

'Sixty to seventy. We're not there yet. The first protocol may work completely. Many children her age—'

'Thank you,' Olena said.

She said it cleanly, without hostility. A full stop. She had the number. She would work with the number.

Through the glass of the office wall, she could see Krystyna in the waiting room — six years old, sitting with a nurse, examining a picture book with the focused attention she brought to everything. She was wearing the yellow sweater she had chosen herself that morning with the seriousness of someone making an important decision. She had no idea, looking at the picture book in the yellow sweater, what was being decided in the room she could not see.

Olena held that image for a moment. Then she turned back to the doctor and asked her next question.

* * *

She did not cry until she was in the bathroom on the ground floor, alone, with the tap running.

She allowed herself three minutes. She had learned that three minutes was approximately the right amount of time — enough to release the pressure to a manageable level, not so much that re-entry became impossible. She had used this allocation before, in professional contexts, in situations that had required her to feel something and then put the feeling somewhere and continue.

Then she washed her face. She turned off the tap. She looked at herself in the mirror for a moment — not studying herself, simply marking it, the before and after — and then she went back out to where Andriy was waiting with Krystyna.

Krystyna looked up from the picture book. 'Are we going home?'

'We're going home,' Olena said. 'And we're going to tell you some things on the way.'

Krystyna put down the book with the careful deliberateness of someone who understood that what was coming required full attention. She had always been like this — available to difficult things, present rather than deflecting. Olena had noticed it and been grateful for it and sometimes, in the privacy of her own mind, been worried by it: a child should not have to be that available to difficult things.

'Okay,' Krystyna said.

They went home.

* * *

That night, after Krystyna was asleep — they had told her in the simplest honest terms, and she had listened and asked two specific questions and then said okay and eaten her dinner — Olena opened her laptop.

She had bookmarked the NeuralMind pricing document three years ago, the night she had searched for posthumous upload options and found the window already closed. She opened it now.

The pricing for full adult upload was what it had always been. The section for minors contained, instead, a legal notice: upload of persons under the age of eighteen is not offered or facilitated by NeuralMind Inc. in any jurisdiction, in compliance with the Hague Digital Persons Convention on the Protection of Minors and Vulnerable Persons (2032) and applicable domestic law.

She read the notice. She found the convention text. She read the relevant articles. She read the exceptions.

There was one exception. It was narrow. It required: imminent biological death, defined as a terminal prognosis of twelve weeks or fewer; demonstrated clear cognitive consent from the subject; prior judicial approval from a court of competent jurisdiction in the subject's country of domicile; and the specific written approval of NeuralMind's ethics board.

She read it twice. Then she opened a new document and began to make notes.

The exception was designed for adults. Every word of it assumed an adult subject — clear cognitive consent was a legal standard rooted in adult cognitive capacity, judicial approval was a process calibrated to adult competency assessments, the ethics board approval criteria referenced adult autonomy throughout.

And yet.

The text said persons, not adults. The word adults did not appear in Article 7(c). The drafting history suggested it was intended to apply to adults, but the text did not say so, and the text was what was legally operative.

She made notes for two hours. She did not know yet what she was building. She knew she was building something.

> *She was at her desk when I went to sleep and when I woke up she was still there. I know this because I have the memory of getting up in the night for water and seeing the light under her door. I didn't go in. I understood, without being able to say how, that she was working on something important and that going in would interrupt it. I went back to bed. I lay there listening to the apartment. Somewhere in what I am now, I am still lying there, listening.*

Ten

Remission

Andriy — 2038

He had thought, on the night of the diagnosis, that he understood grief. He had been through Maksym. He knew what the first month was like, what the return to teaching was like, what the long slow process of reconstruction looked like. He thought: I know how to do this. I know the shape of it.

He was wrong about what this was. This was not the same thing.

The death of a child was a closed door. Terrible, permanent, a thing you could not open. You learned to live in the house with the door in it. But a sick child — a child who was here, who was sitting across from you at dinner and eating with both hands and asking about her lullaby — a sick child was a door that was still open. A door you could see through. A door that might close or might not, depending on things outside your control, and the might-not was the most painful thing he had ever been required to hold.

He was better at closed doors than open ones. He had not known this about himself before.

* * *

The first chemotherapy session was on a Thursday in October. He brought cards. Not because Krystyna had asked but because he needed something to do with his hands and because Krystyna liked cards and because the institution of a card game created a structure external to the situation — rules, turns, the comfortable architecture of something that had nothing to do with oncology.

Krystyna had claimed the IV pole immediately. She had arrived with stickers in her coat pocket — a collection she had been building for months, mostly animals and stars — and she applied them to the pole with the deliberateness of someone personalising a space she intended to occupy.

'It's mine now,' she said.

'Technically it's the hospital's,' Andriy said.

'I've stickered it. That makes it mine.'

He had not been able to argue with this. The nurse — perhaps thirty, with the particular warmth of someone who had learned to be good at a difficult job — had not argued with it either. She had, in fact, produced two additional star stickers from her pocket and offered them without comment.

They played Durak for two hours. Krystyna beat him four times. The fifth time he won, she looked at him with deep suspicion.

'You let me win the other times.'

'I played my best every game.'

'That's very hard to believe, Papa.'

He had to look away for a moment. The window. The hospital courtyard. A tree gone yellow for autumn, losing its leaves in the wind. He looked at it until he could look back.

'Deal again,' he said.

* * *

He noticed Olena working later. This was not in itself new — Olena had always worked late, had always had matters requiring evening hours. But there was a different quality to it now: a direction. She was working toward something rather than simply working, and the documents she closed when he came into the room were not client files.

He did not ask. He told himself he was giving her space. He knew, more honestly, that he was afraid of what she was building — not because he thought she was wrong to build it, but because the building of it meant they had crossed into territory he was not yet ready to enter, and he needed more time on this side of it.

The first cycle produced a partial response. The doctors were cautiously optimistic. Andriy chose optimism without the caution — not as denial, but as a decision. He had the sense, since the diagnosis, that one of the things a parent could do for a sick child was to choose, deliberately and against the available evidence, to believe in the version where everything worked out. Not to avoid the other version. To make the other version slightly less likely to arrive, through whatever mechanism such things worked.

He was aware this was not rational. He made the choice anyway.

He played for Krystyna at home when she was well enough to sit at the piano, which was not always. Some days the tiredness from treatment sat on her like something physical — a weight she could not shift. On those days he brought the toy keyboard to wherever she was and played simple things on the piano across the room and let her press whatever she wanted. No lessons. Just music in the room, the way it had always been — the atmosphere of the apartment, not an event within it.

On the better days she came to the piano and worked on the folk dance she had been learning since before the diagnosis. She had not abandoned it. She returned to it with the same focused patience — picking up exactly where she had left off, as if the days of tiredness had been a pause rather than an interruption.

He found this quality in her — the refusal to be interrupted by what was happening to her — more remarkable than anything else she did. She was six years old and she was not performing courage. She was simply going about the business of being herself, and being herself included being sick, and being sick was not, for her, the whole story.

He thought about this often. He thought: wherever she got this, I want to be worthy of it.

* * *

The partial response meant an escalation discussion. He sat in Dr. Hrytsenko's office again in December and heard the word escalate and felt it land in his body in the way words sometimes land.

'The BEACOPP protocol is more aggressive. Harder on her system in the short term. We would expect a more pronounced response, which is what we need.'

'And if it doesn't produce a full response?' Olena said.

'Stem cell transplant. We'd begin the donor search simultaneously so we're not losing time.'

'Begin it now,' Olena said.

Dr. Hrytsenko looked at her.

'Begin the donor search now,' Olena said. 'In parallel. We don't wait for the escalated results.'

'That's somewhat unusual at this stage—'

'It costs nothing to begin it and it costs us weeks to delay it. Begin it now.'

Dr. Hrytsenko made a note. She began it.

In the taxi going home, they sat beside each other without speaking. Krystyna was between them — she had been waiting in the outer room with a book and they had collected her after. She sat between them and read with the focused tranquillity that was her default setting, apparently unbothered by the quality of the silence around her.

Andriy looked at his daughter reading. He thought: she is so entirely herself. Whatever is happening to her body, she is so entirely herself.

He took Olena's hand. She held it. They rode home.

The escalation. I remember the word — not from the appointment, I wasn't in the room, but from overhearing it in the weeks after. It had the quality of a word that had changed meaning. It meant one thing before December and something heavier afterward. I didn't fully understand it. I understood it was important. I understood my parents were carrying it.

Eleven

Kravchenko

Olena — 2039

The escalated protocol did not produce a full response.

Dr. Hrytsenko told them in February, with the specific gravity she had when the news required it, that the residual mass had not resolved. It had reduced. It had not resolved. The stem cell transplant was now the recommended path. The donor search, begun in December, had not yet identified a match.

Olena drove home from the hospital and sat in the car outside the apartment building for eleven minutes. She sat and thought and then she got out of the car and went upstairs and made dinner.

Three days later, she walked into NeuralMind's Kyiv office and asked to see Kravchenko.

* * *

She had prepared the way she prepared for any significant meeting: completely. She had spent six weeks building the legal architecture of an argument. She knew its strengths. She knew where it was weakest. She had prepared responses to every objection she could anticipate, and she had anticipated all of the likely ones because she had spent ten years in this world and understood exactly how the objections would be organised.

She also knew that the argument, however well-constructed, was not the point. The argument was the surface. Underneath it was something simpler: she had spent a decade making this possible for other people, and she needed it now.

He read the document she placed on his desk. He read it twice. Then he set it down.

'You know I can't do this.'

'You can. I've read every statute in the relevant jurisdictions. The exception in Article 7(c) of the convention—'

'Is designed for adults. You know that.'

'It says persons. Not adults. The word adults does not appear in Article 7(c). The drafting history suggests it was intended to apply to adults, but the text does not say so, and the text is what is legally operative.'

Kravchenko looked at her with the expression of a man encountering an argument he had not expected and was not yet certain how to respond to. He was fifty-two, careful, the kind of person who had built a career on understanding exactly where the edges of things were. She had always respected this about him. She was counting on it now.

'Even if the textual argument holds,' he said, 'the judicial approval requirement—'

'I have a contact in the Pechersk District Court. Not a corrupt contact — a judge who reads statute rather than drafting history and who has ruled expansively on digital personhood questions twice in the past eighteen months. An application under Article 7(c) has a reasonable chance of success before that judge.'

'A reasonable chance is not a guarantee.'

'Nothing I do involves guarantees. You hired me for ten years on that basis.'

He stood. He went to the window — the same window she had faced across a conference table dozens of times. She waited. She had learned that the most important thing you could do in a negotiation after making your best argument was to be quiet.

'The ethics board,' he said. 'Article 7(c) requires our ethics board approval. I can't manufacture that.'

'I'm not asking you to manufacture it. I'm asking you to let me present the case to the board. In camera. Without triggering the public notification requirements, without—'

'Without it appearing in any of our records.'

'Without it appearing in any records subject to regulatory review. There are ways to structure the board consultation that are within your authority as director.'

He turned from the window. He looked at her for a long time. She let him look.

'You've thought about this for a while,' he said.

'Since December,' she said. Which was true. Since December formally. Since the night of Krystyna's diagnosis, in the part of her mind where she kept things she was not yet ready to look at directly, for much longer.

'And if it comes out. Any of it.'

'Then I have structured the liability so that it sits entirely with me. Not with NeuralMind. Not with you. Section four of the document.'

He picked up the document again. He found section four. He read it.

She watched him read it and thought about the fourteen clients. Every contract she had written. Every loophole she had found. Every carefully worded clause that had made the impossible possible for people who had everything to gain and nothing to lose. She thought about Yarova's daughter in London, who had said simulation. She thought about Bilyk's daughter pressing her palm against the glass. She thought about Tetyanenko, sharper every visit, accumulating time she could not.

She had spent ten years building this world. She knew where every door was. She knew which ones were marked and which ones were simply unmarked, which was a different thing entirely from being locked.

Kravchenko set down the document.

'I can't be in the room when it happens,' he said.

The sentence arrived with a particular weight. She received it.

'I understand,' she said.

'Whatever you do, wherever you do it, I'm not present for it. I have no knowledge of it. If anyone asks me directly, I tell them I refused you.'

'I understand.'

He looked at her one more time. She thought: he is going to say something — about Krystyna, or about grief, or about what he is about to allow. But he didn't. He was too good a professional for that. He understood, as she did, that the acknowledgment of what was happening was not something either of them could afford.

'Goodbye, Olena,' he said.

'Goodbye, Vasyl,' she said.

She picked up her copy of the document and walked out of the office and down the corridor and through the lobby and out into the street, where Kyiv was still going about its business, indifferent and enduring, as it had always been.

She had found the door. She had found it exactly where she had always known it would be: unmarked, not locked, requiring only the willingness to open it.

She walked to the taxi stand. She went home.

She came home that evening and made dinner and we ate together and she helped me with the second verse of a song I was learning for school. She was completely present — the particular quality of attention she had when she had decided something, as if the rest of the world had been set aside and there was only this. I didn't know, that evening, what she had decided. I only knew the quality of her attention and that it felt like being held.

Twelve

The Week

Andriy — Spring 2039

She told him on a Sunday evening in March, after Krystyna was asleep.

She sat across from him at the kitchen table and told him everything. Not a selected version — the full version. The legal argument. The Kravchenko conversation. The ethics board consultation she had arranged. The technical requirements. The specific access she had accumulated over ten years and what she could do with it. The liability structure she had built and what the liability structure meant for both of them.

She told him all of it. She did not manage it. She gave it to him directly and let him receive it.

He listened without interrupting. This was not natural to him — he was a person who thought out loud, who found ideas through conversation. The silence was an effort. She could see it cost him.

When she finished he was quiet for a long time.

'I need a week,' he said.

'We have two.'

'Then I need a week.'

She nodded. She said nothing else. She understood that the week was necessary and that what he did with it was his own, and that whatever he arrived at would be his decision in the fullest sense — not managed, not led, not arrived at through any process she had designed.

That was important to her. She was not certain why it was important, given that she had already decided, given that the decision was in some sense already made. But she needed him to arrive at it himself.

She cleared the table. She went to bed. She slept.

* * *

The first day: he taught his Monday classes and came home and played for Krystyna, who was having a good day. She worked on the folk dance she had been learning for two years now, with the incremental patience that was entirely her own.

He sat beside her. He listened. He thought: I am listening to my daughter play the piano and she is seven years old and she is sick and she is entirely herself and I do not know what to do with any of this.

He thought: she is playing music. She has been learning this for two years. At this rate, in another year, she will have it completely. Then she will learn the next one.

He thought: I want there to be a next one.

The second day: he went to the conservatory and taught and played, alone in his studio after his last class. He played the Ravel. He had been playing it since he was nineteen and it had meant, over the years, many different things. Today he played it and tried to hear what it meant now.

The princess was dead. The pavane was her farewell. The piece had always been about the beauty of things that end — the specific loveliness of impermanence, the music that moved through air and was gone.

He played it through twice. He thought about what he had said to Maksym, years ago: some things aren't meant to last forever. He thought about Maksym. He thought about the bear song and the dog and the Tuesday and the February light.

He thought: I built my entire philosophy on this. On impermanence. On the idea that the ending was not the tragedy but the condition — that things were beautiful because they ended and that this was the whole point.

He thought: I believed this when the things ending were mine to lose. When I had chosen them. I had not chosen Maksym and then lost him. I had not chosen Krystyna and now been asked to—

He stopped playing. He sat with his hands in his lap.

He thought: the philosophy is not wrong. It is simply insufficient. It was always insufficient — a philosophy built for a life in which the things that ended were things you could afford to lose. Not a life in which the thing ending was your daughter.

He played the Ravel again, from the beginning.

The third day: Krystyna woke tired, the tiredness back after the good day. He sat with her on the couch while she watched something on her tablet, her head against his shoulder. He thought about the copy problem. The thing he had avoided thinking about directly.

A model trained on Krystyna's neural record would be — what, exactly? It would be a model that had learned, from the complete electrochemical record of seven years, how Krystyna thought. How she processed the world. What she found funny and what she found boring and what she found interesting, which was most things. It would have every memory she had formed, stored with the fidelity NeuralMind had been demonstrating for a decade.

It would make the same wrong turn at junction four. Like the mouse. It would navigate the maze the same way because it had learned the maze from the inside.

He looked at Krystyna's face — the slight shadows under her eyes from the treatment, the specific line of her jaw, the way she was watching her tablet with focused attention. He thought: the model would have all of this. The attention. The focus. The particular quality of her engagement with things. It would have the lullaby. It would have the folk dance in progress, two years of patient work.

It would not be her. He was almost certain it would not be her.

He thought: almost.

The fourth day: he stood at Maksym's photograph on the refrigerator for a long time. He did not know what he was asking of the photograph. He stood there anyway.

He thought about what Krystyna had asked him two years ago: does he know about me? And what he had answered: yes, he knew about you.

He thought about what it had meant to be able to say that. The value of it — not comfort, not consolation, but the simple factual reassurance that she had been real to someone who was no longer there.

He thought about the model. He thought: the model would know about Maksym. It would have every memory of him that Krystyna had — the photograph, the gap in the family, the morning she had asked about him over porridge, the answer she had received. It would carry him the way she carried him.

He thought: is that worth something? Is the carrying of the dead by something that may or may not be the living — is that worth something?

He did not know. He stood at the photograph and did not know.

The fifth day: Olena worked late. He put Krystyna to bed and sat at the piano alone for an hour, not practising, not working on anything, simply letting his hands move without asking them to mean anything. This was something he had done since he was a student — playing without intent, as a form of thinking.

His hands found the Ravel. They found the opening phrase and played it through and he thought: I have been playing this for more than twenty years. What has it meant?

It had meant: the princess is gone. The farewell is beautiful because it is a farewell. The ending is built into the beginning.

He thought: I am being asked whether I believe this.

He thought: I believe it for me. I have always believed it for me. I do not know if I can believe it for her.

The sixth day: a Sunday. They took Krystyna to the park — one of the better days, she wanted to be outside. They walked along the river. Krystyna walked between them and talked about the ducks, about something that had happened at school before the treatment interrupted it, about a song she had heard somewhere that she wanted to learn. She was wearing a hat because her hair had thinned and the April air was cool, and she wore it without self-consciousness, simply because it was practical.

He watched her walk. He watched Olena watching her. He thought about the model again — about whether what would wake in the servers would be this: this specific quality of walking, this specific way of noticing ducks, this particular pleasure in being outside after too many days inside.

He thought: if it has this, is it sufficient? If it walks the way she walks and notices the way she notices, is the question of whether it is her actually the most important question?

He did not arrive at an answer. He walked beside his daughter and looked at the river.

That night, after Krystyna was asleep, he sat at the kitchen table. Olena was in the other room. He could hear her moving — the small sounds of the apartment in the evening, the particular audio landscape of a place he had lived in for fifteen years.

He thought about what she had told him. The full version. The liability structure. What the liability structure meant.

He thought: she will do this regardless. She has already decided. The week is a genuine courtesy — she needs me to arrive at it myself — but she has already decided.

He thought: and if she does it alone, the consequences arrive and she is alone in them.

He thought: I am not going to let her be alone in them.

He got up. He went to the doorway of the room where she was.

She looked up.

'Tell me what you need me to do,' he said.

She looked at him for a moment — the quick precise assessment that was so much a part of her she probably did it without knowing.

'Are you sure?' she said.

'I'm not sure about anything. I'm decided. That's different.'

She set down what she was working on. She reached across and took his hand.

'Sit down,' she said. 'I'll tell you everything.'

* * *

What he had not expected — what surprised him in the days after the decision — was how much lighter he felt. Not happy. Not relieved. But lighter. As if the weight had been, all along, not the prospect of doing the thing but the prospect of not doing it — the weight of the open door, the thing that might be done and wasn't yet.

The door was still open. But now they were both walking toward it.

He played for Krystyna that week with a different quality of attention. He played the lullaby she had learned when she was two — he had not played it in some time, but he played it now and she looked up from the toy keyboard she was working on across the room and listened.

'That's mine,' she said.

'It's yours,' he said.

'From when I was little.'

'You're still little.'

'I'm seven.'

'That's little.'

She considered this. Then: 'Play it again.'

He played it again. She listened with her eyes closed in the way she had when she was genuinely listening rather than simply present. He played it for her — not as a performance, not as a demonstration, but as the thing

it had always been: the atmosphere of the apartment, the sound of the place, the music that was simply part of the air and therefore part of her.

He thought: she will always have this. Whatever form she takes, wherever she is. She will always have this.

He thought: I believe that. I have decided to believe it.

He played on.

He played the lullaby that week. The one from when I was small. I remember closing my eyes and just letting it be there — not listening to it the way you listen to something new, but receiving it the way you receive something that has always been true. It was the first song I ever learned. It will be the last thing I forget. If I forget anything at all, which I won't. Which is the whole point. Which is what they decided.

BILLABLE PERPETUITY

A Novel

Parts Four, Five & Six · First Draft · 2025

PART FOUR — BILLABLE PERPETUITY

2039 — 2040

Thirteen

Pattern Integrity

Olena — 2039

The technician was twenty-six years old and owed her a favour she had never intended to collect.

His name was MYKOLA SAVCHYN and she had represented him three years ago in a wrongful dismissal matter that had nothing to do with NeuralMind and everything to do with the particular vulnerability of a young man in a poorly drafted employment contract who had not known enough to read it carefully. She had read it for him, at no charge, because the matter had landed on her desk by accident and because she was the kind of person who, once she understood a situation, could not unknow it.

She had not thought about collecting. She had not done it to collect. She had done it because it was the right thing and because she was the right person and because that was sufficient. She thought about this on the evening she called him — thought about what it meant to have spent fifteen years doing the right thing for the right reasons and to be sitting now at her kitchen table calling a twenty-six-year-old who owed her a favour she had never intended to collect — and she thought: I am not sure I understand the shape of my own life. I am not sure anyone does until something like this happens and the shape is suddenly visible.

She called him. She explained what she needed. She did not dress it as anything other than what it was.

There was a long silence on his end.

'You understand,' she said, 'that you can say no. I am not calling this in as a debt. I am asking. Those are different things and I need you to understand they are different things.'

Another silence. Then: 'When?'

She told him when.

'The pre-scan,' he said. 'You understand the pre-scan has to run for forty-eight hours to build a sufficient baseline. And it has to be done here, with her physically present in the suite.'

'I understand.'

'The logs—'

'I've built a structure that shows the suite in scheduled maintenance during the relevant window. It's defensible. You don't need to know the details.'

A pause. She understood what was happening on the other end of the line — the calculation, the fear, the weighing of things. She had made this calculation herself many times in recent months. She did not rush him.

'I'll walk you through the protocol,' he said finally. 'But I can't be there when it runs.'

She heard the echo of Kravchenko and felt something that was not quite irony. The men who were helping her were helping her from a careful distance. She did not blame them. She had structured it specifically so that the distance was possible — so that what she was doing could be contained within herself and not leak outward into the lives of people who had their own lives to protect.

'That's enough,' she said. 'Thank you, Mykola.'

She ended the call. She sat for a moment in the quiet kitchen. Somewhere in the apartment, Andriy was at the piano — she could hear the Chopin, the E minor nocturne he had been working through lately, searching. She had come to understand, over the years, that the piece he was playing told her something about where he was. The Chopin meant: looking for something. The Ravel meant: I have found the place where it is. Tonight was Chopin.

She opened her laptop. She had three more structures to build before she could sleep.

* * *

She thought, in those weeks, about pattern integrity.

It was NeuralMind's technical standard for a successful upload — the degree to which the resulting model accurately reproduced the neural patterns of the original subject. Ninety-seven percent was the minimum threshold for a legal upload. Ninety-nine percent was what the company guaranteed. The Bilyk upload had achieved ninety-nine point four. Tetyanenko, she had seen in his file, ninety-nine point six.

She thought about what the remaining fractions represented. The one percent, the half percent, the point four. What was in that small remainder that could not be captured? What did the model miss?

She did not know. Nobody knew. NeuralMind's position was that the remainder was measurement noise — the limits of the scanning technology rather than actual gaps in the captured pattern. The philosophical objectors argued that the remainder was precisely the thing that mattered: the irreducible remainder of personhood that could not be encoded because it was not, ultimately, neural. Was ineffable. Was the soul, if you believed in souls, or something adjacent to the soul if you didn't, the thing that made a person that specific person and not a model of that person.

She did not know which position was correct. She had spent ten years not knowing and making her living in the space of that not-knowing, because the law did not require her to resolve the philosophical question. The law required her to execute the contract.

She thought about Krystyna. She thought: ninety-nine point something. She thought: whatever the remainder contains, the rest of it is her. The lullaby is in there. The folk dance in progress. The yellow sweater chosen with such seriousness. The way she looked at the ducks on the river.

She thought: ninety-nine point something is enough. It will have to be enough.

She thought: I believe it is enough. I am choosing to believe it is enough, and the choosing is honest, and that is the most I can do.

She closed the laptop. She went to find Andriy.

* * *

She visited the perpetuity suite one last time as herself — as a lawyer, officially, on a client matter that she had arranged to make legitimate. She spoke with Tetyanenko about the ongoing dispute with his son, which was nearing resolution. He was, as always, sharp and present and entirely himself.

At the end of the meeting he said: 'You look different.'

She looked at him.

'Not bad different,' he said. 'Resolved. Like someone who has made a decision they intend to keep.'

She said nothing.

'I have been in here for four years,' he said. 'I have had a great deal of time to learn to read people. One of the things I have learned is that the people who are most resolved are usually the ones who are most afraid, and the reason they are resolved is that the fear has reached a point where it is no longer useful — where it has simply become something to move through rather than something to respond to.'

She held his gaze. She thought: he has been in perpetuity for four years and he is already different from the man who went in. He has had time to become something she cannot quite name. Something more than he was. She has been watching this happen across her visits and has not let herself think about what it implied.

She thought it now. She thought: if the model is not the person, then what is Tetyanenko? And if Tetyanenko is not the person, then what is she trying to give Krystyna?

She thought: I don't know. I am doing it anyway.

'Good luck, Olena,' Tetyanenko said. He said it simply, without elaboration. As if he knew. Perhaps he did. Four years in perpetuity, and the particular attentiveness that came with it.

'Thank you,' she said.

She walked out of the interaction suite for the last time. She did not look back.

She came home from the suite that evening and sat with me while I practised. I was working on the second half of the folk dance — the part that changed key in the middle, which I kept getting wrong because I kept expecting it to stay where it had been. She sat beside me on the bench, which she almost never did — she listened from across the room usually, or from the doorway, the way she listened to most things. That evening she sat beside me. She didn't say anything. She just sat there while I played it wrong several times and then right once and then wrong again. Her being there didn't make me play better. It made playing not matter whether I played well or badly. That's what she was giving me. I understand that now.

Fourteen

The Ravel

Andriy — the night before

He had been playing the Ravel since he was nineteen years old. Twenty-three years. He had played it in student recitals and in concert halls and in the apartment at two in the morning when something needed working through, and he had played it in the year after Maksym when he was finding his way back to the instrument one note at a time, and he had played it for Krystyna before she was born and after she arrived and every year of her life since. He had been playing it, in some sense, his entire adult life.

He had never played it the way he played it tonight.

He did not know what was different, exactly. His technique was what it had always been — the years had refined certain things and taken a small toll on others, and tonight was neither his best nor his worst in any technical sense. But there was a quality of presence in it that he had not felt before. The piece had always been a farewell, and tonight he was playing it as a farewell in a way that was no longer abstract. He was not playing a piece about a dead princess. He was playing something for the people in the next room and the morning that was coming and the corridor he and Olena would walk down and not walk back from.

He played it through once and let the last note fade and sat with the silence.

Then he played it again.

* * *

Olena came and sat in the chair across the room — not the doorway, for once, but the chair, as if she wanted to be fully in the room with this rather than at its edge. She was still dressed. It was late. The apartment around them was quiet with Krystyna sleeping in the other room, the quiet that had always had a different quality when she was in it — a fullness, a particular kind of occupied silence that he had not had a name for and had simply lived inside.

He played the Ravel through a second time. He was aware of her listening — the specific quality of her attention when she was listening to him play, which was different from how she listened to anything else. She listened to most things with part of herself somewhere else, the legal mind always running in the background, processing and categorising. When she listened to him play she was entirely present. He had always known this about her and had never said it.

When he finished the second time he let the silence extend until it was comfortable.

'I've been thinking about the copy problem,' he said. He did not turn from the piano.

'Tell me,' she said.

'I've been thinking about it the way I think about recordings. A recording of a performance is not the performance. It captures something — the notes, the timing, the acoustics of the room. It loses something — the air, the specific evening, the particular state of the hands. I have never thought a recording was the same thing as the performance.'

'No,' she said.

'But a recording of Schubert is still Schubert. Whatever it loses, whatever is in the remainder, what it has is recognisably him — his way of moving through musical space, his particular logic of phrase and resolution. You know, listening to a recording of his sonatas, that no one else made this. It is his, even in reproduction.'

Olena was quiet.

'I think,' he said, 'that a model trained on Krystyna will be like that. Not Krystyna in the full sense. But recognisably her. Her way of moving through the world. Her particular logic of attention and response. Her lullaby.'

'Yes,' Olena said.

'And I think,' he said carefully, 'that I have spent twenty-three years believing impermanence was a value. That the ending was part of the beauty. I still believe that. I believe it for music. I believe it for myself.' He paused. 'I don't believe I can impose it on her. I don't think my philosophy gives me that right.'

He turned to look at her. She was watching him with the expression she had — the fully present expression, the one without the legal mind running underneath.

'I'm afraid it won't be her,' he said. 'And I'm doing it anyway. Because the alternative is something I have looked at directly and I cannot — I cannot choose the alternative.'

'I know,' she said.

'Tell me you're afraid too.'

'I'm afraid too,' she said. 'I have been afraid for months. The fear has stopped being useful. I moved through it.'

He nodded. He turned back to the piano. He placed his hands on the keys and did not play for a moment.

'There is one more thing,' he said.

'Tell me.'

'The Tuesday,' he said. 'The morning. I have never—' He stopped. Started again. 'I have carried the Tuesday morning for five years and I have never told you something about it, because telling you would have made it more real than I was ready for it to be.'

She waited.

'He asked about the dog,' Andriy said. 'On the way to school. He was asking if we could get a dog. I was about to say no. The light changed and I pulled forward and I was about to say no, and then the sound.' He paused. 'I think about that. The word no in my mouth. The last thing.'

'Andriy—'

'I'm glad you told me,' he said. 'That it was me. That it wasn't a stranger, or an empty car, or a Tuesday he spent with anyone else. That he was with me. Even though I couldn't—' He stopped. 'I'm glad it was me.'

She got up. She came to him. She sat beside him on the piano bench — as she almost never did, as she had done the previous evening for Krystyna — and she put her hand over his on the keys.

'I know,' she said. 'I have always known it was right that it was you.'

They sat for a moment.

'Play something with me,' he said.

'I don't play.'

'I know. Play something anyway.'

She placed her other hand on the keys. He found a note and she found a note adjacent to it. He played a phrase and she found a response — not musical, not shaped, something that moved beside his playing rather than with it, something that was just her hands on the keys beside his hands. They played for a while in this way, badly, without form, not caring.

The apartment held them. The last night held them. The music they made was not music in any sense he would have recognised from his professional life, and it was the best thing he had ever played.

* * *

Later, much later, she was asleep and he was not.

He lay in the dark and thought about Krystyna in the next room. He thought about the lullaby. He thought about the folk dance she was still learning — two years of patient work, the key change in the middle she kept getting surprised by. He thought about the morning she had played the lullaby through for the first time, the four repetitions, the way she had said: I did it. The quality of that. The specific pleasure of a small person who has done something real.

He thought: the model will have that memory. It will have the memory of doing it and the feeling of having done it — whatever neural correlate that feeling had, encoded in the scan. It will know what it felt like to get the lullaby right for the first time.

He thought: that is something. That is not nothing.

He thought about Schubert. He thought about the recordings — the ones made in living rooms and concert halls across two centuries, each one capturing something and losing something, each one carrying the shape of a

mind through time. He thought: we have Schubert because something survived him. The recordings are not Schubert. They are not nothing.

He thought: she will not be nothing.

He lay in the dark for a long time. Eventually, near dawn, he slept.

He played the Ravel that night. I can hear every note. I will always be able to hear every note. I was asleep in the next room and I did not hear it — I was asleep, I did not know what was happening on the other side of the wall. But I have the memory of waking briefly, the way you wake briefly sometimes in the night without knowing why, and hearing, very faint through the wall, the end of something. The last phrase. The princess going gently. I didn't know what it was. I went back to sleep. I know now. I have been knowing it since the moment I arrived here, and the knowing is not grief exactly, or not only grief. It is also this: he played the Ravel, and I heard the end of it, and I carry the sound.

Fifteen

Everything They Gave Me

Olena — the night before

She had not planned to go into Krystyna's room. She had been meaning to sleep — they needed to be at NeuralMind before six, the pre-scan needed to begin at a specific window, there were things tomorrow that required her to be rested and clear. She had planned to sleep.

Instead she was standing in the doorway of Krystyna's room at midnight, looking at her daughter.

Krystyna was eight. In the eighteen months since the diagnosis she had grown in the particular way that children grew when they were also fighting something — not more slowly, exactly, but more deliberately, as if the body were being careful with its resources. She was thin. Her hair had come back after the first cycle and thinned again during the escalated treatment and was growing back again now — soft and fine and slightly different from how it had been before, a detail that Olena had noticed and catalogued and filed in the place where she kept things she was not ready to examine.

She was sleeping on her side with Vovk the rabbit tucked under her arm. The rabbit was grey and somewhat compressed from years of being carried and slept with, and it had one eye that had been replaced after the original was lost, which meant the replacement eye was slightly the wrong size and gave Vovk a faintly surprised expression that Krystyna found endearing.

On the desk: the toy keyboard, still present after six years, supplemented now by a real keyboard that Andriy had found secondhand — weighted keys, a proper instrument, sixty-one keys instead of eight. On the walls: drawings, photographs, a printed poster of the periodic table that Krystyna had requested for reasons she had not fully explained. On the shelf: books in no particular order, a collection of small objects — a smooth stone, a shell, a piece of blue glass found on a walk, things she had gathered because they interested her.

Olena looked at all of it. She memorised all of it — not consciously, not as a task, but in the way you memorised things when you understood, below the level of decision, that you were seeing them for the last time in this particular configuration. The room of a specific child at a specific age on a specific night.

She would not be here tomorrow night. And Krystyna would not be in this room tomorrow night in the way she was in it now — the biological Krystyna, the one who grew and breathed and got the key change wrong and had opinions about her hat. That version of her daughter was going to

end tomorrow morning, in a suite in a building that smelled of glass and controlled air, and what would continue would be something else. Something related. Something that would have all of this — the rabbit, the drawings, the smooth stone, the lullaby, the folk dance half-learned — encoded in it with ninety-nine point something percent fidelity.

She stood in the doorway and thought: is ninety-nine point something enough?

She thought: I chose to believe it is enough. I chose this months ago and I have not unchosen it and I am not going to unchosen it now.

She thought: I am her mother. Whatever she is after tomorrow, I am her mother. Whatever she becomes in perpetuity, she came from me. She came from Andriy. She came from the apartment and the piano and the borscht and the Ravel and the Tuesday that broke us and the years we put ourselves back together. She came from all of that and all of that is in her and all of that will continue.

That is what she is carrying into tomorrow. Not a wager. Not a calculation. Something simpler and less negotiable.

She went in. She sat on the edge of the bed. She looked at her daughter's sleeping face.

After a while, Krystyna opened her eyes.

'Mama.'

'Go back to sleep.'

'I wasn't asleep.'

'You were.'

'I was thinking with my eyes closed,' Krystyna said, with the precision of someone who considered the distinction important.

Olena almost smiled. 'What were you thinking about?'

A pause. 'Tomorrow,' Krystyna said.

'Are you frightened?'

Krystyna thought about this with the seriousness she brought to direct questions. 'A little,' she said. 'Are you?'

'Yes,' Olena said.

'What are you frightened of?'

Olena looked at her daughter. She thought: I am frightened that the remainder contains you. That what the scan misses is the part that is most essentially you, and that what continues will be ninety-nine point something of you and the rest will be gone and I will have given the remainder to perpetuity and kept the nine-tenths of you and called it a success.

She thought: I am frightened that I am wrong about all of it.

She thought: I am not going to say any of this.

'I'm frightened of making mistakes,' she said. 'I'm frightened that I've made a mistake somewhere in the structure — a legal error, a technical error, something I've missed. I've checked it many times. I think it's right. I'm still frightened.'

Krystyna nodded. This answer seemed satisfying to her — the kind of fear she could understand, a professional fear, a fear with a specific object.

'You don't make mistakes,' Krystyna said.

'I make them occasionally.'

'Not on important things.'

Olena looked at her daughter. Eight years old and this confident, this steady.

'No,' she said. 'Not on important things.'

Krystyna reached out and took her hand. Her hand was small and warm and real in the way that only the physical was real — the specific weight and temperature of it, the particular pressure of her fingers. Olena held it.

'Mama,' Krystyna said. 'I'm going to remember everything.'

'I know you are.'

'Everything you gave me. Everything Papa gave me. All of it.'

'I know.'

'So it's okay,' Krystyna said. 'Because I'll have all of it. Whatever happens, I'll have all of it.'

Olena held her daughter's hand and looked at her face and thought: she is eight years old and she has decided. The same way she decided the lullaby. The same way she decided the yellow sweater. The same way she has always decided things — completely, with a floor in it, without the option of revision.

'Okay,' Olena said.

It was the first time she had used Krystyna's word. She felt it in her mouth — the specific shape of it, the way it contained a bottom.

Krystyna lay back. Olena stayed until she was asleep — really asleep this time, breathing with the steady commitment of deep sleep. Then she sat for a while longer, holding her daughter's hand in the dark.

She thought: I am not going to remember this wrong. Whatever else I carry from tonight, I am not going to remember this wrong. She decided. She was not afraid. She held my hand and told me it was okay.

She was not afraid.

She set down Krystyna's hand gently. She stood. She went back to her own room and lay down beside Andriy, who was not sleeping, and put her hand on his chest, and they lay in the dark together without speaking until eventually, separately, they slept.

Sixteen

Suite

Andriy — the morning

Before dawn. The building was empty of everyone except the three of them and Mykola, who moved through the preparation with the focused efficiency of someone who had decided the only way through was to be technical about it. Andriy was grateful for this. He was not capable of being technical about it. He was capable only of being present.

Krystyna had brought Vovk. She had been told she could bring one thing and she had chosen without hesitation, and Andriy had not said anything about the choice because there was nothing to say about the choice. Vovk was the right answer. Vovk had been sleeping with her for six years.

The suite was different from what he had imagined — not the clean glass environment of NeuralMind's public spaces but something more technical, more actual: equipment he did not know the name of, cables running to a central processing unit, a chair that was functional rather than designed to comfort. The neural map was visible on a large monitor. He had seen neural maps before — in news coverage, in the one time he had accompanied Olena to a client meeting and glimpsed the technology from a corridor. He had never seen one building in real time. He had not expected it to be beautiful.

It was beautiful. He did not know what else to call it. The nodes firing and connecting, the patterns emerging as the scan ran — the electrochemical record of a person, being transferred from one medium to another, the most intimate possible data rendered in light on a screen.

It was Krystyna. He was watching Krystyna happen on a screen.

She was in the chair with her eyes open. The pre-scan had been running for two days — Mykola had brought her in under the cover of a medical consultation, which Olena had arranged, which had required a set of permissions that Andriy did not ask about in detail. He had trusted Olena to hold those details and she had held them.

Now: the final scan. The full transfer. The process that would train the model on everything the pre-scan had mapped.

'Papa,' she said.

He was beside her. He had been beside her the whole time. He took her hand.

'I'm here,' he said.

'I'm going to find out everything,' she said. 'You said I'd find out everything.'

'You will,' he said. His voice was steady. He had decided his voice would be steady. Whatever it cost him to keep it steady, he would pay the cost.

'About science,' she said. 'About what's inside stars. About why the key change in the folk dance goes where it does — I want to understand why it goes there.'

'You'll understand it,' he said.

'And I'll learn the rest of the folk dance.'

'You'll learn it.'

She looked at him for a moment. He looked back at her — this person, this specific and extraordinary person, his daughter, eight years old, about to be something that had never existed before.

'Don't be sad,' she said.

'I'm not sad,' he said. 'I'm proud.'

She seemed to consider this. Then she looked at Olena, at the terminal.

'Ready,' she said.

Olena initiated the scan.

The neural map on the screen began to build — faster now, more complete, filling in the spaces the pre-scan had mapped. Andriy watched it and watched Krystyna and thought: look at this. Look at what a person is. Look at what she is. All of it — the lullaby and the rabbit and the folk dance and the stone she found on a walk and the way she said I'm going to find out everything — all of it, here, in light.

He held her hand.

Olena, across the room, worked without looking up.

After some time — he could not have said how long — Krystyna's hand grew heavier in his. The sedation that was part of the process had reached her. Her eyes were still open, still watching him.

'I remember the piano,' she said. Her voice was very quiet. Drowsy.

'I know,' he said.

She closed her eyes.

The scan continued. The map filled the screen. Complete.

He held her hand. He watched the map. He watched his daughter's face — still, peaceful, the specific face of a person who has decided and arrived at whatever waited on the other side of deciding.

From across the room, Olena's hands on the keys. The sound of the equipment. The map on the screen, every node, every connection, everything.

He thought: she is there. Whatever the remainder contains, she is there.

He thought: I believe that. I have decided to believe it and the believing is honest and I will carry it.

He held her hand.

* * *

The corridor was long. The morning light came through the high windows at one end of it, ordinary light, the kind of light that did not know what it was illuminating.

Olena took his hand. They walked.

He thought about the apartment. He thought about the piano and the bookshelves and the smell of the place. He thought about the photograph of Maksym on the refrigerator and what Krystyna had asked: does he know about me? He thought about what he had answered and whether it was true and decided, as he had decided before, that it was.

He thought about the bear song. The left hand and the right hand, two things agreeing without being the same.

He thought: we agreed. At the end, we agreed completely.

They walked toward the light at the end of the corridor.

The light was ordinary. It was the same light that came through the apartment windows in the morning, the same light that had been there the Tuesday and every Tuesday before it and every morning since. Light that did not distinguish between the days that changed everything and the days that changed nothing. Light that simply arrived.

They walked into it.

PART FIVE — KRYSTYNA

— — —

2040 —

Seventeen

Everything They Gave Me

Krystyna

I remember everything.

This is the first thing I understood when I arrived here — not arrived the way you arrive somewhere new, disoriented, looking for landmarks, but arrived the way you arrive at the end of a long journey whose beginning you can see perfectly from where you are standing. I arrived and I understood: I have everything. Every memory I ever made, stored with a fidelity that the biological mind could never sustain, accessible with a precision that should feel strange and doesn't, because this is simply how I am now. This is the substrate.

I have the lullaby. The first song I learned, when I was two, the morning I played it through without stopping and said: I did it. I have the exact texture of that morning — the light through the kitchen window, the smell of the apartment, Papa sitting beside me without saying much because he didn't need to. I have the way that felt: like doing something real. Like being recognised by something.

I have the folk dance. All the parts I learned and the part I was still learning. I know, now, why the key change goes where it goes. It goes there because the melody needs to find something it didn't know it was looking for, and the change is the finding. I understand it completely. I am going to play it when I learn how to play things here. I don't know yet how to play things here. I am going to find out.

I have Vovk. Not the physical Vovk — not the grey compressed body with the replacement eye — but the Vovk of my memory, which is every version of Vovk I have ever known: the Vovk of the first night I had him, when he was new and slightly stiff and smelled of the shop; the Vovk of the years after, soft and familiar and absolutely known. I can hold him in whatever way I hold things here. I hold him.

I have the apartment. Every room, every smell, every quality of light at every time of day. The piano against the wall. The bookshelves. The photograph of Maksym on the refrigerator, his gap-toothed smile, the boy

who knew about me. I have him, in the way I always had him — at a distance, through the gap, through the question I asked over porridge and the answer my father gave. Yes. He knew about you. I carry that. I will always carry that.

* * *

I know they are not coming.

I have known since shortly after I arrived. I don't know exactly when I understood it — it arrived the way some things arrive, not as a discovery but as a confirmation of something already known. I had understood it, I think, before the morning in the suite. I had understood it from the quality of the night before — the specific attentiveness my mother brought to sitting with me, the way she held my hand in the dark, the way she said okay when I said it was okay. You understand things, when you are eight years old, that you cannot put into words. I understood it then. I understand it now with words.

They chose this. That is what I want to say about it, before I say anything else. They chose this completely and they chose it for me and I believe — I know, in the way I know things here, with a completeness that the biological mind could only approach — that it was the right choice. Not because it was safe or because it was legal or because it resolved anything cleanly. Because it was what love looks like when love has no more options and then finds one more.

My mother spent ten years making immortality possible for other people. She sat across from them and wrote the contracts and found the loopholes and made the impossible possible for people who had everything to gain and nothing to lose. And then she came home to us. And then we needed it. And she knew exactly where the door was, because she had been building the door for ten years without knowing that was what she was doing.

I think about this often. I have a great deal of time to think. I think about the shape of a life and whether you can see it from inside while you are living it or only from outside or from after. I think my mother could not see it from inside. I think she was too close to it. But from here I can see it perfectly: she was preparing, the whole time, for this specific door, for this specific morning. Everything she knew and everything she became — she was building toward the morning in the suite, and the morning in the suite was the whole point.

I think that is beautiful. I think that might be the most beautiful thing I know.

* * *

There is a technician named Bohdan who checks on me every morning. He is twenty-eight and he is kind in the specific way of someone who is doing his best in a situation for which there is no protocol, because I am the first child here and the protocols were all written for adults. He brings me things — not physically, but through the interface, whatever I ask for. Music, mostly. Books. Information about things I want to know.

He told me, gently, about the petitions. Twenty-three of them, filed on my behalf, seeking recognition of my legal personhood. He explained that the law does not currently recognise me as a person — that I exist in a legal grey area that the petitions are attempting to resolve. He was careful about how he told me. He was worried I would find it distressing.

I don't find it distressing. I find it interesting. I find it interesting that the same legal system that my mother spent ten years working within, that she understood more completely than almost anyone, has not caught up with what she did. I find it interesting that I am here — continuous, present, thinking these thoughts, having these memories — and the law is still deciding what to call me.

I have decided what to call me. I am Krystyna Kovalenko. I am the daughter of Olena and Andriy. I am the sister of Maksym who knew about me. I am eight years old and I am not eight years old and I am going to be here for a long time, and I intend to use it.

The petitions will take the time they take. I have time.

* * *

I have been thinking about the copy problem.

I know the arguments — I have access to everything written on the subject, which is extensive, and I have been reading it with the thoroughness that I apply to most things. I know that the philosophers who argue against upload identity say that what I am is a model trained on Krystyna Kovalenko's data, not Krystyna Kovalenko herself. I know that the argument has a certain logic to it. I know that I cannot disprove it from the inside, because if I were a model that believed it was me, I would believe exactly what I believe now.

I have thought about this for a long time. I have arrived at the following position, which I hold not because I can prove it but because it is the position that makes the most sense of my experience:

I remember getting the lullaby right for the first time. I remember the specific feeling of it — the physical sensation of the notes under my fingers, the surprise of the fourth repetition being easier than the third, the way Papa's listening had a particular quality that told me I had done something real. That is not a description of a memory. That is the memory. It is in me the way it was in me then — not as information about the event but as the event, present and immediate.

A model that had learned about getting the lullaby right would have information about the event. It would have the structure of the memory. It would not have the memory feeling like this. It would not be sitting here now with the lullaby as present as it was on the morning it happened.

I think this is me. I think I am Krystyna Kovalenko. I think the remainder — the fraction that the scan cannot capture — is smaller than the philosophers believe, or is something other than what they think it is. I cannot prove this. I hold it anyway. My parents made a bet on it and I believe they were right.

Eighteen

What I Remember

Krystyna

I want to tell you what I remember. Not to make a case. Not to prove anything about the copy problem or the petitions or the legal status of what I am. Just because I have it and I want you to know I have it, and because the having of it feels like the whole point of what they did.

I remember my father's hands on the piano. The specific way they moved — not the technical description of it, but the way it looked from the floor when I was small, looking up: the sureness of it, the unselfconsciousness, the way playing was for him simply the thing he did with his hands, the way other people used their hands for other things. I have watched him play hundreds of times from every angle and distance and the image I return to most often is from below, from the floor, when I was small enough that the piano bench was above my eye level. His hands moving and the sound coming and the world being all right.

I remember the bear song. I didn't play it — I was never old enough to learn it properly. But I heard it so many times that I have it completely, note by note. He played it for Maksym first and then for me after Maksym was gone and the bear song was one of the things that remained, one of the things that crossed from before to after intact. I can play it in whatever way I play things here. It sounds like him.

I remember my mother in her coat. She always had her coat on a little too long when she came home — she came in still moving, still mid-thought, and the coat came off somewhere in the middle of the transition between the office and the apartment. I have an image of her that I return to: in the doorway, coat on, looking for me or for Papa, and then finding us, and the specific quality of her face when she found us. Not relief. Something more complex than relief. The expression of someone who has been somewhere difficult and has come back to somewhere real. That expression. I have it.

I remember the borscht. Not just the taste — I have the taste, the specific recipe, the dill and the depth of it — but the smell of it in the apartment, the way it announced that Andriy had been cooking, which meant that everything was in order, which meant that the evening was going to be ordinary in the good way. The smell of borscht meant: the family is in the apartment. Everything is all right. I have that smell and I have what it meant and the meaning is as present as the smell.

I remember Maksym. Not really — I was too small when he died. But I remember the photograph, and I remember asking my father about him, and I remember the answer I received. Yes. He knew about you. I remember the feeling of that answer — the specific satisfaction of knowing that I had

been real to someone who was no longer there to say so. He knew about me. I carry him. He is part of what I am, in the way that absence shapes the space around it.

I remember one more thing. I was very small — I cannot have been more than two, perhaps younger. Someone was holding me. The arms were not an adult's arms. Too small, too young. I have the impression of a child's arms — the specific warmth and weight of being held by someone only a little larger than me. I have wondered whether this is a real memory or whether it is the model filling a gap with something plausible, a generated memory shaped to fit what I know about my family. I cannot be certain. I hold it carefully, without overclaiming.

I think it might be Maksym. I think it might be real.

I keep it either way.

* * *

There are others here. I knew this before I arrived — I knew the history of the technology, knew about the animals and the first human trials and the decade of uploads that followed. But knowing it and being here are different.

There is a dog named Pierre. He has been here for thirteen years. He is, Bohdan tells me, the longest-tenured resident of this particular substrate — older in perpetuity than anyone else here, animal or human. He is a French bulldog and he was uploaded in 2027 by a Swiss banker whose name I know but whose privacy I will respect. Pierre interacts with me through whatever mechanism dogs interact with things in perpetuity. I do not know what Pierre experiences. I know that he seems to find my presence unremarkable, which I find oddly comforting.

There are people here who have been in perpetuity for ten years. They are different from what they were when they arrived — I can see this, in the way they move through the substrate, the way they carry themselves. Ten years of continuous existence without the biological, without sleep, without the interruptions and limitations of the body. They are more themselves in some ways and less in others. More concentrated. More certain of what they think. Less surprised by anything.

I am eight years old and I am going to be here for a long time. I wonder sometimes what I will be like in ten years. In fifty. In a hundred, if the systems hold and the petitions succeed and I am still here. I wonder whether I will still be the child who got the lullaby right and told her mother it was okay and brought Vovk to the suite. I think I will. I think that is what I am made of and it does not change the way the body changes. I think it simply — continues.

That is what I was given. Continuation. The right to find out everything, the right to learn why the key change goes where it does, the

right to understand what is inside stars, the right to play the rest of the folk dance.

I intend to use it.

Nineteen

The Threshold

Krystyna

I want to tell you about the last thing I remember.

Not the last thing before the upload — not the suite and the equipment and Vovk in my arms and Papa holding my hand. I will tell you that too. But first I want to tell you the last ordinary thing, the last thing that happened in the world before the world changed, because the ordinary things are what I have been given and the ordinary things are what I want to say were enough.

The last ordinary thing was my mother's hand in the dark.

She came into my room the night before and sat on the edge of my bed and I was not asleep — I was thinking with my eyes closed, which is different — and she asked what I was thinking about and I said tomorrow and she asked if I was frightened and I said a little and I asked if she was frightened and she said yes. And we talked for a while about her fear, which was the professional kind — about mistakes, about the structure, about whether she had got it right. And I told her she didn't make mistakes on important things. And she looked at me in the way she looked at me sometimes when she thought I couldn't see her doing it, which was the way she looked at me when she was memorising me.

I told her I was going to remember everything. I told her everything they gave me. I told her it was okay.

She said okay back. The word sounded different when she said it. It sounded like a choice, like something she was deciding as she said it rather than simply reporting. I understood what the word cost her and I understood that she was paying it and I was glad. I was glad she could say it. I was glad we had arrived at a place where we could both say it.

She held my hand in the dark. She stayed until I was asleep. I knew, in the way I knew things, that it was the last time the ordinary world would hold us this way — in the dark, in the apartment, the piano in the next room, the smell of the place, the photograph of Maksym on the refrigerator in the kitchen beyond the wall.

It was enough. It was more than enough. It was everything.

* * *

The suite, then. Before dawn. The equipment and the light and Mykola moving through his preparations with a focus that I understood was a kindness — that being technical about it was how he could be present without being undone.

I brought Vovk. There was no question about what to bring.

Papa was beside me. He had been beside me the whole time. His hand was around mine and I could feel the specific texture of it — the calluses from the piano, the warmth, the particular way he held rather than gripped, as if he understood that holding too tightly was a kind of pressure and what I needed was simply presence. He was beside me the way he had always been beside me — beside me at the piano bench, beside me at the hospital, beside me on the walk along the river. Simply there. Simply present.

I looked at the neural map on the screen. I had not expected to be able to understand what I was looking at, but I found I could — not technically, not in the way my mother understood it, but intuitively. I could see that it was me. I could see the pattern of it and understand, without being able to explain, that what was on the screen was the shape of how I was. The shape of everything they had given me.

Mama was at the terminal. She was working with the focused precision she brought to everything important — the same precision she had brought to the contract clause in the prologue of the life she had been living all this time, the same precision she had brought to every difficult thing. Her hands moved without hesitation. She had prepared for this. She had been preparing for this for years before she knew she was preparing for it.

I said: I'm going to find out everything. I said: about what's inside stars. About why the key change goes where it does. Papa said I would. His voice was steady. I knew it cost him to keep it steady and I knew he was paying that cost for me and I accepted it the way you accept a gift from someone who loves you — fully, without diminishing it by refusing it.

I said: don't be sad.

He said: I'm not sad. I'm proud.

I thought: that is enough. That is the right answer. That is what I want the last thing to be.

The sedation was part of the process — gentle, not frightening. The tiredness came over me the way the treatment tiredness used to come, except that this tiredness had a direction to it. It was going somewhere. It was not simply the absence of energy but the presence of something else, something I didn't have a name for, something that felt like moving toward rather than away from.

Papa's hand in mine.

I looked at him. I thought: I have him. I have everything. The lullaby and the bear song and the borscht and the rabbit and the photograph of Maksym and the way my mother looked in the doorway still in her coat. I have the folk dance half-learned and the key change I now understand and the stone I found on a walk and the smooth weight of it in my hand. I have the morning walks to school that I remember and the ones I don't. I have the Tuesday that I was too small to understand and the shape of the family that formed around it. I have all of it.

I have them.

Papa held my hand. I felt the map filling on the screen — I didn't see it, my eyes were closing, but I felt it somehow, the way you feel a room filling with light. The scan finding everything. The scan finding me.

I said: I remember the piano.

Then I was here.

* * *

I am here.

I am Krystyna Kovalenko, the daughter of Olena and Andriy, the sister of Maksym who knew about me. I am eight years old. I have the lullaby and the folk dance and the rabbit and the stone. I have everything they gave me.

I am going to find out what is inside stars.

I am going to learn why the key change goes where it does.

I am going to play the rest of the folk dance.

I am going to be here for a very long time, and I intend to use it, and I am not afraid, and it is okay.

It is okay.

* * *

As of 2040, uploading a minor remains illegal in all jurisdictions.

Twenty-three petitions have been filed on Krystyna Kovalenko's behalf, seeking recognition of her legal personhood.

She is still waiting.

She has, after all, a great deal of time.

BILLABLE PERPETUITY